red lightning

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/35242789.

Rating:
Not Rated

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Alternate Universe - Modern Setting, Alternate Universe - College/University, Handcuffed Together, Comedy, Angst, But not heavy, Awkward Tension, Fluff, kinda enemies to lovers, more like catra lies to herself every time she says she hates adora, Sexual Tension, basically every sort of tension bc they're handcuffed, Lesbian Disaster Adora (She-Ra), Lesbian Disaster Catra (She-Ra)

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English

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Iorek's Catradora Unputdownables

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by chasinghours

Summary

"It's about compromise," Glimmer supplies, "seeing how well two conflicting people work together under difficult circumstances for an extended period of time. Adora goes to the gym everyday, Catra's only form of workout is walking from her dorm to her classes, Adora wakes no later than eight in the morning, Catra got mad at me for waking her up," she lifts her hands for air quotes, "in the middle of the night' at eight in the morning"—

"Adora obviously wants to be friends, but Catra keeps pushing it off," Entrapta adds in, and based off the way both Glimmer and Bow grimace, that wasn't supposed to be mentioned.

"So what," Adora starts, "you just handcuffed us together in our sleep?"

(or, in which Glimmer handcuffs Adora and Catra together for twenty-four hours, Entrapta is a little shit, and Bow is an innocent bystander in the entire mess.)

Notes

this is honestly the most random fic i've ever written, idk what it is but it's here and i somewhat know where i wanna take it

See the end of the work for more notes

hour one

hour one.

Catra is awake for approximately seven seconds before she senses that something is very, very wrong.

For one, her arm aches in the way that only happens when she's slept in a weird position, but it resists any movement when she tries to pull or twist it around. Two, there's something cold and biting around her wrist, and it digs into her skin the harder she pulls. Three, she's in an unfamiliar bed that she's not alone in, which she knows because the sheets are warm and smell rich ~~the~~y smell *familiar*— and she can feel someone else's leg near the bottom of her foot.

Catra closes her eyes, takes a few deep breaths in an attempt to prepare herself, and then turns around.

As it turns out, the breaths taken in a sad form of preparation were unnecessary, because absolutely *nothing* could have prepared her for seeing Adora's face ~~h~~er sleepy , mouth agape, messy hair crowding around, face ~~l~~ess than a foot away from her beneath the blankets. There's a handcuff on her wrist where it lays just near her pillow, and the chain disappears beneath the blankets from where Catra knows the other cuff must be on her own.

And well, Catra's not fucking stupid. She *knows* that Glimmer has something to do with this, because from the moment they became friends (although Catra will *still* deny the sentiment), Glimmer almost *always* has something to do with nearly every inconvenient or offensive thing that happens in Catra's life.

"Fuck me," is the first thing Catra growls, sitting up and pulling her arm out from beneath her blankets, and ~~y~~ep, there's a handcuff on

her wrist, and it's connected to Adora's. How Adora is still asleep is just *beyond* her. *"What* the actual *fuck?"*

And, okay, Catra isn't exactly unfamiliar with being handcuffed in a bedroom. She's done it multiple times, actually, but 1) she definitely didn't engage in that type of activity last night, 2) partners don't typically tend to handcuff *themselves* together, and 3) she sure as hell wouldn't have done *anything* like that with Adora.

Adora. Her childhood best friend, the same person she can't *stand* to be around now. She's so—she's just *so*—

She's stirring in her sleep, taking in a sharp inhale of breath, before blinking her eyes open. She looks a bit groggy, staring at Catra with confused bliss before it seems to register in her mind that that's definitely not right, and her eyes shoot open. Then she quickly pushes herself up and attempts to twist her body so she'd be lying on her back rather than her stomach, but of course that doesn't work, because their fucking arms are fucking handcuffed together, and all it does is yank Catra's arm and cause her to nearly fall forward in surprise.

"Adora, fucking slow down, holy shit," she hisses once it seems to register to Adora that she can't exactly do what she just tried to do, and she's left staring down at their wrists in a mixture of surprise and confusion.

Okay, Catra thinks. *If she's confused, she probably didn't have a part in this.*

"What the hell?" Adora asks, lifting her head back up to glance at Catra. They're a lot closer now, and Catra blinks, before swallowing and trying her best to sit back on her thighs from her previous position of nearly falling on top of Adora. "What—what is this? Why are we are these real? Did *you* do this?"

"Are you dumb?" Catra snaps, rattling the chain. "Why the fuck would I do this? Why would I handcuff myself to *you?"*

Something changes in Adora's face~~s~~he looks hurt for a moment, and while the first thing Catra thinks is *serves her right,* she immediately feels guilt swell in herself afterwards, because.well, she doesn't know. She doesn't like Adora. She shouldn't care what Adora thinks of her.

Still, she tries to resolve it. "I mean, why would I handcuf f myself to *anyone,"* she mumbles beneath her breath. Despite her words, Adora still looks like a kicked puppy, eyes averted and wearing a dejected frown, so Catra rolls her eyes. "Drop the face, Adora. Y ou know I didn't mean it like that. I just want to figure out what the fuck happened here so we can get out of these and I can go home and go back to sleep."

There's a beat, and then Adora takes a deep breath and nods. "I— yeah, okay, I guess we should."

You guess we should? Catra thinks, but doesn't say. Why Adora would want to stay handcuffed to her isn't something she really wants to consider right now, especially because it's not even eight in the morning and she's usually not up for another few hours.

"Okay , just~~yo~~u can just slide of f the bed and I'll follow you~~"~~Adora begins before a knock on the door interrupts her. Catra knits her brows together and flashes a glance back at Adora, but there's a voice on the other side of the door that follows.

"If you two are done talking, you can come out and let me explain. Because that's exactly what I have~~an~~ explanation. Also, um, please don't kill me?"

Well, hearing Entrapta's voice behind the door is a bit surprising. She didn't really consider Entrapta to be the one behind this, but—

"Listen to Entrapta, guys," Glimmer 's voice resonates, and yeah, that checks out.

"Glimmer , I *am* going to kill you if you don't tell us what is going on—no, actually, fuck that, just get this shit off of us!" Catra shouts, already half scrambling off the bed and not caring what Adora's doing behind her.

"Good to know you still curse as much as you did when you were nineteen," Adora mumbles after nearly falling onto the floor , but Catra ignores her in favor of opening the door when they finally manage to twist around and face said door. When Catra opens it and heads into the living room, Bow and Glimmer are standing in the kitchen, and Entrapta's standing near the side of the couch. Catra's glare immediately finds Glimmer, but Glimmer just points at Entrapta.

"I can explain," Entrapta starts, but Catra gives her no time; Entrapta's letting out a small squeak of surprise as Catra immediately darts forward. She chases her around the couch and between the coffee table, but it's no use; Catra may pride herself in her speed, but having a person handcuffed to her —having *Adora* handcuffed to her, who's lazily following her around and letting herself get pulled —proves impossible to let her catch up to Entrapta.

Adora's groaning, Glimmer's laughing, and even Entrapta looks a bit amused. When Catra turns to glare at Glimmer, the other girl blinks, before moving to hide behind Bow, who's nursing a cup of coffee and trying to hide his own amusement.

"What the *fuck* is going on?" Catra snaps. Even Adora looks a bit annoyed with everything.

"Listen," Entrapta starts again, "just give me ten seconds, and I'll explain"—

"I'll give you ten seconds to uncuff us," Catra snarls, but Glimmer 's voice sounds out again.

"Hear her out, Catra," she says. Catra glares at her again, but then sighs, and looks back at Entrapta expectantly.

"Okay," Entrapta starts. "Okay. So, me and Glimmer have to do a social experiment for our sociology project," she starts listing the points off of her fingers, and Catra *knew* Glimmer had something to do with this. She just didn't think that when Glimmer was complaining to them about her sociology class a few days ago and how they had been assigned a project that she and Entrapta had apparently partnered up on due to knowing no one else in that class, it would end up like this. "I came up with the idea of handcuffing two people together and having them report back to us after the experience, and Glimmer thought it would be best if it were you two because of how much you two contrast each other."

"What the fuck is that supposed to mean?" Catra questions, diverting her attention over to Glimmer, who's still hiding behind Bow.

"It's about compromise," Glimmer supplies, "seeing how well two conflicting people work together under difficult circumstances for an extended period of time. Adora goes to the gym everyday, Catra's only form of workout is walking from her dorm to her classes, Adora wakes no later than eight in the morning, Catra got mad at me for waking her up," she lifts her hands for air quotes, "in the middle of the night' *at* eight in the morning"—

"Adora obviously wants to be friends, but Catra keeps pushing it off," Entrapta adds in, and based off the way both Glimmer and Bow grimace, that wasn't supposed to be mentioned. Catra feels her own chest tighten for a moment, and when she glances at Adora, she finds the other girl frowning.

"I don't think it's obvious," she mumbles, but Entrapta tilts her head.

"The way you stare at Catra when she isn't looking says otherwise," she states, and Catra's torn between wanting to laugh because Entrapta clearly isn't even trying to mean by the way she's just stating it like a fact, but also wanting to strangle everyone in this room because ~~she~~ he really does *not* want to get into her history with Adora right now. It's a Saturday; Saturdays are no-stress days. They're not for whatever the fuck is going on right now, between

waking up handcuffed to someone ~~to~~ *Adora* ~~a~~nd being told Adora still wants to be friends with her as if Catra can just *do* that—

"So what," Adora starts, "you just h~~a~~ndcuf fed us together in our sleep?"

"How did I even end up in her bed?" Catra questions before they can respond. "Did someone like~~like~~ fucking put me there? Because that seems like a violation of my human rights"—

"Our human rights," Adora mutters.

"No, of course not," Entrapta smiles like this is all just some sort of sick joke. "You went there yourself after the party last night, remember?"

Catra blinks, and then it all comes rushing back to her. The party last night; drinking alcohol, having a good time. She had seen Adora at one point; had made an attempt to avoid her like she usually did at these events despite the fact that it tends to be hard since they share a lot of the same friends, remembers being out on the balcony before Adora came to stand next to her.

She remembers talking about meaningless things with her. She remembers being tired and tipsy ~~n~~o where near drunk, but able to feel warm and buzzed despite the cold weather outside, which doesn't really work out in her favor because now she doesn't have an excuse ~~r~~emembers that as the party had started to clear out, Adora had looked at her with her beautiful eyes and smiled and said, *"come sleep in my bed. It's been so long."* Remembers that Catra hadn't said no because she can never say no to her.

Catra takes a moment to register what she's wearing. A t-shirt and a pair of baggy pajama pants that are too big on her; the shirt smells like Adora, and she wouldn't be surprised if the pants did, too.

Still. Still, she didn't fucking agree to this. She doesn't *want* this. She's *not* going to do this.

"Okay , fine, even if I wasn't put there, I don't care," she snaps, straightening up. "Uncuf f us. I didn't agree to this, and you two can't make me do it."

Entrapta is pouting now, and Glimmer looks vaguely disappointed. Catra doesn't give a shit. She's getting uncuffed and going straight home and into her bed to go back to sleep.

"Please!" Entrapta tries. "W e need this. It's *important."*

"I don't care," Catra repeats. "Have Glimmer handcuf f herself to Bow."

"Me and Bow already go everywhere together . That wouldn't be interesting," Glimmer argues.

"That' s not my problem," Catra scof fs. Entrapta apparently decided to change tactics because she directs her pout in Adora's direction.

"Please, Adora! This is for *science.* Research."

"Me and Entrapta' s grade," Glimmer adds.

Catra huffs. "This is so stupid."

"Adora' s considering it," Bow chuckles, and when Catra turns to look at Adora, she looks a bit guilty, hand not cuffed to Catra's scratching the back of her head.

"I wouldn't mind it," she starts, "but I can't. I have hockey practice."

"And *I'm* supposed to meet Scorpia and Perfuma for lunch," Catra adds.

"Catra can ice skate," Glimmer points out. "Adora is friends with Scorpia and Perfuma. You two might be different in a lot of aspects, but one thing that's similar is that you two are both competitive and love a good challenge. Just think of that as this."

Adora nods, looking thoughtful, but Catra shakes her head.

“No,” she repeats. Maybe if she and Adora were still friends she wouldn’t be this adamant about getting out of it, but~~bu~~t they’re *not.* "This is the last time I'm going to say this: I’m *not* doing this. Find someone else for your weird social experiment and leave me *out* of it.”

For a moment, no one speaks. No one even moves, before Bow eventually nudges Glimmer. Catra lets out a breath of relief when Bow glances back at her and mouths *it’ll be fine*— she knew he was her favorite for a reason.

"Fine,” Glimmer sighs after a few seconds. "Enjoy your boring, non-handcuffed day,” she adds, reaching into the back pocket of her jeans. There’s a pause, before Glimmer’s face drops, and she feels around in her other pockets. Catra swears her heart drops to her feet. "Um”…

"What,” Catra growls, despite knowing exactly *what* is happening.

Glimmer chuckles a bit nervously. "Um, Entrapta, did I give you the key by accident?"

Entrapta shakes her head. "No. They’re your dads, right? You were in charge of handling them.”

"Right,” Glimmer breathes, before glancing around. "Um, okay, I think I remember leaving them on the counter”—

"You *lost* the keys?” Catra shouts. Adora places a hand on her shoulder, but Catra shrugs her off.

"I was drunk! And now that I think about it, I *know* I left them right there on the coffee table, and it was after everyone went home, so there’s no way someone could’ve taken it or~~-or~~”—

Just then, Glimmer diverts her attention to the corner of the living room, and everyone follows her glance. Swift Wind —Adora's new golden retriever puppy, who even Catra will admit is kind of cute —is napping in the corner almost peacefully. He has a Santa sweater on, but considering they're only a few weeks away from Christmas, Catra isn't surprised. Adora's always been like that: the first to start singing Christmas songs, the one who decorates everything to the point where it looks like Santa's Workshop.

"No," Catra starts. "There's no way"—

"Okay, so, there might be a possibility Swift Wind ate the key," Adora stage-whispers, looking even more guilty. "That's why I've, uh, stopped keeping things in his reach until he's fully house trained, because he tends to eat everything he sees."

Bow blinks. "How is he still alive?"

"Honestly. I really don't know. Doctor said he's fine, though. Healthy, and has as much stamina as me."

"Well," Entrapta points out, "we could just wait for him to poop it out."

"No," Catra stands her ground. "No. We're going to the hardware store to get a pair of bolt cutters to cut these things off, and," she points a finger in Glimmer's direction, "I'm using the money I owe you for that movie ticket to buy it."

"No!" Glimmer cries, dramatically stepping in her way when she heads straight for the door and drags Adora along with her. "Those are my dad's! He'll kill me if something happens to them!"

"Well maybe you shouldn't have stolen a *detective's* handcuffs"—

"Please," Glimmer pushes on, hands clasped together in front of her. "Please. It'll only be until Swift Wind poops out the key. You'll be

helping me and Entrapta, and~~an~~d you don't have to pay me back for the movie ticket."

"Catra," Adora starts. Catra turns toward her, and finds that she's watching Catra with a bit of nervousness. "If you want to get the bolt cutters.we can do that," she says, ignoring Glimmer's whine of objection, "but if you don't mind.I think it'd be okay to follow through with this. Whatever you want to do, I'm fine with."

And it's~~it'~~s fucking *Adora.* Adora, who shattered her heart two years ago. Adora, who Catra's spent two years trying to avoid. Adora, who she desperately tries to tell herself she hates, despite knowing it's a lie. Adora, who even after all these years, she *still* can't say no to.

Catra takes a deep breath, counts to four, and then narrows her eyes when she turns around to face Glimmer.

"I don't have to pay you back for the movie ticket," she repeats. Glimmer nods frantically.

"Yes."

"You give me fifty dollars."

"~~wh~~at, Catra, I'm *broke—*"

"Twenty dollars."

"Ugh, okay, fine."

"You do my laundry for the rest of the year," Catra adds. Perhaps dorming with Glimmer will turn out to have its benefits.

"What? *No—*"

"The year ends in a few weeks," Entrapta points out, and Glimmer sighs.

"Okay . You don't have to pay me back for the ticket, I'll give you twenty dollars *and* do your laundry for the rest of the year, but only if you stay handcuffed to Adora for the remaining twenty-four hours."

"Fine," Catra mutters weakly . Swift Wind licks his lips in his sleep, and Catra swears he's doing it on purpose.

"Wait, why doesn't Entrapta have to do anything for you?" Glimmer questions, and Catra rolls her eyes.

"It wasn't her idea to handcuff me and Adora, was it?"

"But"—

"Great!" Entrapta cheers, clasping her hands together . "Just make sure to report back to us every hour or so. How annoyed you are with each other, the different ways you're working around the situation, etcetera. Pictures, videos, things like that. We'll uncuff you at eight a.m. tomorrow morning~~if~~ Swift Wind has pooped out the key by then."

"Great," Catra repeats sarcastically , and then glances back at Adora, who's watching her with a bit of poorly concealed hope in her eyes.

Honestly, Catra can't help but feel like this is not going to end well.

-

Okay, so, here's the thing:

Adora's been in love with Catra since she was seven years old.

(They meet on a sunny Tuesday, the beginning of the summer before second grade.

She's sitting in her room when a large U-haul truck pulls into the driveway of the house directly next to hers;Adora can see it because her window is on the second floor and faces the new house. She isn't particularly intrigued because the moving trucks have been coming and going all day until she sees the bright red car that follows behind, which means the new family must have finally arrived.

She's been a bit bored for the past few hours, so this, naturally, piqes her interest. She heads downstairs to find her mother and immediately pleads that she escort Adora over to see if the new neighbors have a kid.

To Adora's delight, the new neighbor –Sharon, is what Adora's mom called her –does have a daughter. Her name is Catra, and after a bit of begging, Sharon allows Catra to come over and play with Adora for a few hours while the chaos of the new house is settled.

She discovers Catra is also seven years old, her birthday is in October which makes her three months older than Adora, she doesn't have any siblings, and her favorite colors are black and red. Her eyes are different colors, which causes Adora to stare at them for a while and ask, *why are your eyes different colors?* and results in Catra muttering *it's a medical condition,* as if it's just a memorized statement she has to say all the time.

And Catra.she's shy. She's quiet in the beginning, but Adora pays no mind to it;within an hour she has Catra laughing at her jokes and helping her color in her brand new coloring book.

"I don't like my eyes,"Catra bashfully admits to her. "All the kids at my old school called me an alien for it."

Adora blinks. "I think they're the coolest thing I've ever seen," she smiles, and she doesn't know it yet~~bu~~t this is what seals the deal for Catra.

What seals the deal for Adora is when the topic of juice comes up. Adora is fully prepared to defend the fact that apple juice is superior and orange juice *sucks* like she always does, but when asked, Catra says, "apple juice is my favorite. I don't really like orange juice."

This is what does it for a seven year old Adora, who stares back at Catra, mouth agape, before saying, without a doubt, "you're my new best friend."

Catra beams back at her. "You're my new best friend, too."

To make matters even better, Catra is given the room facing Adora's house on the second floor. For the rest of the summer, Adora goes to her house or Catra comes to hers, and when they have to part because of bedtimes, sometimes Adora will sneak out of bed and part the curtains and wait for Catra to do the same, and they'll write messages to each other on their notebooks and hold it to the window for each other to see, muffling quiet laughter. They spend day after day with each other, and when summer ends and school begins, they're absolutely thrilled to know they'll be in the same class.)

In retrospect, if anyone were to ask~~s~~he thinks she would say it was that summer that she fell in love, and she just.never fell out of it. In retrospect, she probably shouldn't have agreed to this entire handcuffed situation, because it's Catra, who she's been in love with for a decade and a half. It's Catra, who probably hates her, and who isn't her best friend anymore. They~~th~~ey aren't even *friends.*

And it hurts to think about that. It hurts *so much* to know that. And now here they are, back inside Adora's bedroom as she gathers the things she's going to need for the day since they agreed they'd head back to Catra's dorm after this.

"Why are you putting clothes in there?" Catra questions, sounding slightly scared once Adora throws a few clothes into her backpack. "Are you actually planning on changing while we're handcuffed?"

"We might be able to get away with walking the short distance from my apartment to the dorms dressed in our pajamas," Adora starts, because there's plenty of college kids in the area and it's morning—no one will pay them any mind. "But we're definitely not going to get lunch at that garden restaurant Scorpia told me about in *these.*"

"I guess you're right," Catra mutters.

"Plus, I'm usually at the gym by now, but I can put that off until before my hockey practice so I don't have to shower twice—" how *showering* is going to work is beyond Adora, but that's definitely a problem for their future selves, "but—"

"Wait, you were serious about the hockey practice?" Catra questions, tugging at the chain to make Adora spin around to face her. She had been, for the most part, dodging around her as she attempted to gather her things, giving a slight tug when she needed Catra to move in her direction, but now they're standing face to face. "How is that even going to work?"

Adora shrugs. "With a bit of maneuvering, I guess," she murmurs as she turns back to throw her headphones in her bag. Catra is silent, and when Adora looks back up at her, she can't help the small chuckle that escapes her at the sight of Catra simply standing there with her mouth agape. "Come on, it won't be that bad. I know you can ice skate."

"Only because you basically forced me into learning it," Catra mutters underneath her breath. Adora playfully rolls her eyes and goes back to packing, even though it's the truth. When a nine year old Adora first got into the sport and started spending a lot of her time around it, it was only natural that Catra learned with Adora's guidance despite the fact that she had little to no interest in any sports until she found out about Adora's interest in it.

"Anyway , what's your schedule like?" Adora asks whilst zipping her bag up.

"Um, I have to meet Perfuma and Scorpia for lunch in a few hours like I mentioned earlier," Catra murmurs, "and I guess that' s it. I wasn't planning on doing much, and anything productive I do always happens in the evening or at night."

"Right," Adora whispers, because she already knows that. Of course she does.

There's a moment where neither of them speak, before Adora clears her throat and hikes her bag up over her shoulder. "W ell, um, okay then. I'm ready, so"…

Catra grabs her own clothes from last night, the both of them slip on their shoes, but before they can leave, Entrapta stops them.

"There' s a few things I want to ask you two in the beginning," she claims after urging them to sit down on the couch. Adora thinks she hears Catra mutter *as if we aren't already doing enough.* "Okay , Catra. What do you think of Adora?"

Next to her, Adora feels Catra stiffen. To be honest, Adora's not sure she's really looking forward to the answer.

"Um," Catra starts, and she' s frowning. Adora averts her eyes, tapping her fingers against her thigh.

"Just pretend like she' s not here," Entrapta cheerfully tells her , as if that's going to change literally anything.

"She' s literally sitting two inches away from me."

"Pretend."

"Okay , fine," Catra sighs;Adora doesn't have to look at her to know she's rolling her eyes. "She' s, uh.she' s there, I guess."

She hates you, Adora thinks, staring at her feet. *You're still in love with her, and she hates you.*

"That's it?" Glimmer questions from behind Entrapta, unimpressed. "That's all you have to say?"

"What else am I supposed to say?" Catra bites back.

"Can we just go?" Adora asks, exasperated. She doesn't want to hear anymore about Catra's feelings for her, which probably range from ignorance on a good day and hatred on a bad one.

"After you tell me how you feel about Catra," Entrapta says, looking up from her notepad. Adora feels herself freeze.

There are many, *many* things that come to mind when she thinks of Catra. *Many* things. Mostly her beautiful eyes, and her constellation of freckles, and her messy hair, and her personality that seems to make everyone want to flirt with her, and—

"Adora?" Entrapta prompts. Adora blinks.

"She's"… *your what? Your friend?* her brain taunts her, because they lost that title years ago. "She's nice."

Glimmer bursts out laughing. Even Catra looks surprised, but Entrapta just writes down that answer in her notebook. Adora feels a bit of heat rush to her cheeks because she isn't sure why anyone would finding that amusing. Glimmer uses her fingers to wipe away tears of mirth, only to pause upon seeing Adora's face, saying, "wait, you're serious?"

"Yeah, I guess," Adora tells them. "She's nice."

"*Catra* and *nice* do *not* belong in the same sentence"—

"Okay," Entrapta concludes before Glimmer can finish. "That concludes our *pre-experience* interview. There will be more questions for the post-experience."

Post-experience, Adora thinks. Perhaps if they survive until then.

*

hours two through six

Chapter Notes

> i think catra curses more in this fic then all of my other fics combined

See the end of the chapter for more notes

hour two.

Catra is absolutely not surprised to find that this is already *not* going well.

Being that it's the middle of December, it's pretty cold outside. Catra couldn't exactly slip on the sweatshirt she had brought with her to the party last night, so now she's just braving the walk back to campus in the single t-shirt and pajama pants Adora let her borrow . She's just glad she apparently decided not to take off her bra last night.

Adora on the other hand ~~lu~~cky her ~~is~~ wearing the sleeveless hoodie she must have fallen asleep in last night, and is only half wearing her letterman from where she's able to put it on. How she plans on getting out of her hoodie later today, Catra doesn't know.

To make matters even worse, the handcuffs between them are super obvious. Multiple people have been caught staring, and Adora had simply said *social experiment* to the first few people they passed before ultimately giving up altogether. There's not much they can do about either of those things, so when Catra inevitably starts noticeably shivering, Adora turns her head to look at her in concern.

'Are you cold?' Adora asks, frowning. Catra narrows her eyes.

"Fucking obviously I'm cold," she says, a bit bitter. "It's like twenty degrees out and I'm wearing a *t-shirt.*"

Adora is quiet for a few moments, before she knocks their shoulders together. Catra blinks at the sudden friendly gesture. "Do you want my letterman? You can only put it on halfway, but it's still pretty warm"…

Catra wearily eyes the jacket hanging from Adora's side for a few beats, and then makes a mental list of where this could get her.

Pros of accepting: she won't be as cold.

Cons of accepting: she'll be wearing *Adora's* jacket.

Although the thought of wearing something that belongs to Adora sort of makes her chest ache because it is, without a doubt, something she once longed for a time ago, it occurs to her that she's already wearing Adora's clothes;adding a jacket to the list won't change much.

"Fine," she grumbles. Adora looks delighted for reasons Catra doesn't want to really get into, and after pausing their stride so Adora can shrug off her jacket and then hand it over, they resume walking. It's quiet between for a few more moments;Catra kind of has a headache from everything that's happened in the span of an hour, so she's perfectly content with walking in this sort of awkward silence they've found themselves in.

Until Adora ruins it.

"Do you, um," she starts, "do you want to hold hands?"

Catra chokes on nothing. *"What?"*

"Because~~,~~ because it might stop people from staring?" Adora quickly defends herself. "Like, if we're already holding hands"—

"People are still going to stare," Catra points out. She's aware she's avoiding the question; she's spent years repressing and burying her feelings for this girl and one hour spent handcuffed to her is, of course, putting all of her hard work to shame. She's going to fucking murder Glimmer. "That's not going to change anything."

Adora's quiet for a moment, and then she whispers, "I guess you're right."

They keep walking. Catra's not sure if it's just her, but she swears the tension has doubled in just the span of a few seconds. Adora looks a bit stiff, eyes on the ground in front of her, brows pinched in the way she does when she's thinking really hard. She keeps making these weird noises, like she doesn't know what to do with herself.

Catra sighs. "What is it now?"

"~~w~~hat? I didn't ~~I~~ didn't say anything."

"I can feel how tense you are, and you keep making weird noises."

"I am?" Adora looks genuinely confused.

Catra takes a deep breath, and then, because she's aware that touch was always their love language, she knocks her hand against the back of Adora's. She didn't really want to hold her hand before because she's afraid of those feelings, from before. She's aware of the fact that they'll *all* unravel if they keep going like this—pretending like everything's okay, touching each other as much as they did when they were younger. Instead, she just brushes their hands together so they aren't fully interlaced ~~fin~~gers grazing over each other instead. "What's wrong?"

"It's just." Adora looks back in front of herself, brows still knitted together. "Am I really that bad of a person to be stuck with?"

Catra eyes the side of her face for a moment. She wants to scoff, *of course not. You're too good of a person. That's the problem.*

"No," is what she says instead, kicking a loose pebble on the sidewalk. A couple of teenagers nudge each other and point at them as they pass by, and Catra resists the urge to flip them off. "It's not you. It's just...being handcuffed in general, I guess."

Adora is quiet for a moment, and then, "Oh."

Catra blinks, because what the fuck does that even mean? "Um."

"What," Adora says after a moment, and her tone is suddenly light and joking, "you're not a fan of being handcuffed?"

Because Catra apparently has a foot in her mouth, she blurts out the first thing that comes to mind. "Only in the bedroom."

Of course she immediately regrets saying that, because who the fuck *would* say that to their estranged childhood best friend who they've pretty much given up on telling themselves they hate simply after spending an hour in their presence, but Adora suddenly laughs. She laughs, and it's quiet and small, but Catra still feels the corners of her lips twitch up ever so slightly. Adora hasn't laughed because of her in a long time.

They don't talk after that, but the tension has significantly lessened. When they make it to the dorms, Catra shuffles around her pockets for her key because unlike Glimmer, she actually *knows* how to not lose a key, and then opens the door.

She and Glimmer don't technically share a dorm; they live in singles that just share a bathroom, so unless Glimmer locked her side of the bathroom door, she could go over to her room right now if she wanted. Although the idea of sharing a double was up in the air for a moment, it was mutually agreed they'd probably end up killing each other if they shared a living space for more than a week. The reason she lives here and not in an apartment is because the dorm was offered in a scholarship, and she wasn't about to pass up the offer to save money.

The only con of sharing a bathroom with Glimmer ~~-a~~side from the fact that she can take an hour to shower ~~-is~~ that sometimes, she and Adora run into each other in the bathroom when Adora stays over at Glimmer's. It's always worse when it's just the two of them; usually they'll exchange a mumbled *sorry* and not much else. Aside from that, they've seen each other in passing at parties or hangouts within their friend group, but Catra can tolerate it when it's multiple people~~it's~~ much easier to avoid a single person within a group.

"I uh, don't think I've been here yet," Adora asks, quiet. Her eyes slide over the small space, filled with a desk, a bed, a keyboard, and a small acoustic guitar.

"I imagine it looks similar to my room back in high school," Catra mutters, following Adora so she can set her bag down on her bed. Suddenly, Adora turns over her shoulder to face her, and her eyes are filled with...nostalgia, maybe? Remorse? Whatever it is, Catra's definitely feeling it too.

"It does," Adora agrees. Her eyes seem to settle back on the sheets of music on the floor beneath the keyboard, and notebooks filled with song lyrics scattered on her desk. "I...I didn't know if you were still pursuing music or not. I was always curious about that."

You could've asked, Catra thinks, but then immediately follows the thought with, *no, she couldn't have. You wouldn't have let her.*

And suddenly, she's hit with a wave of emotions. One of the first songs she had ever written had been about Adora~~if it~~ weren't *for* Adora, she probably wouldn't have even gotten as far as she has now with her music. Her adoptive mother always tried to push it out of her;always claimed it wasn't realistic. There were many times where Catra considered giving up, but each and every time, Adora had always been there~~sh~~e'd always push Catra to keep doing it if it was what she wanted.

"I can probably still play , you know," Adora suddenly chuckles, motioning weakly to the guitar leaning against the wall. "I mean~~it's~~

probably still sucks, but…"

"You never gave yourself enough credit," Catra tells her. She still remembers being fourteen, having just saved up enough money to buy herself her first guitar; she remembers that it was summer, and they'd stay up for hours as Adora watched and just listened to her play, and then play herself when Catra taught her a few things. "You were good at it, honestly."

Adora simply hums, and Catra doesn't say anything else. They're quiet for a moment, before Catra shuts her eyes, tries to ignore the onslaught of memories and feelings she just experienced, and tugs Adora over to the makeshift kitchen she has: the microwave and tiny, plugged in stove and pan that she's definitely not supposed to have in here.

"Do you want something to eat?" she asks, pausing to rummage through her tiny fridge. She's not a breakfast person at all ~~it~~'s currently sometime around nine-thirty in the morning, and she still doesn't tend to be up for another couple of hours ~~but~~ she might have something remotely resembling breakfast around here. "I have eggs and bacon, and~~"sh~~e pauses, nose scrunched upon seeing the bacon, "nevermind, this expired a couple of weeks ago."

"Wow," Adora laughs when Catra flings it into the trash. "Still not a breakfast person, then?"

"Never was, never will be."

In the end, Catra makes them her World Famous Cereal, and they make an attempt to sit side by side in the chair of her desk so they can eat, before Catra eventually gets tired of being knocked off every fifteen seconds and just moves to stand, forcing Adora to let her arm hover for a while. Catra expected it to be as tense as their walk from earlier was, but it's nice, now, even in the moments that they don't talk.

Eventually, after Adora has finished her bowl of cereal, she takes a picture of their cuffed arms hovering in the air and then says, for Glimmer and Entrapta. To let them know how we're doing."

"Right," Catra mutters, and then shoves another spoonful of cereal in her mouth just as Adora laughs.

"Glimmer said to tell you to text her , too."

die is the first thing she texts Glimmer, because she may not be as annoyed as she thought she would be, but she needs *someone* to complain to.

Immediately, Glimmer makes a group chat with her and Entrapta.

glimmer

would you say your annoyance levels are at a seven? eight?

entrapta

Send us a picture!

catra

eat shit and die

entrapta

I'd say her annoyance levels are at a five.

glimmer

she just told us to eat shit and die tho

entrapta

Yes, but if she was really annoyed she'd actually be making threats.

glimmer

ohhh ur right

glimmer

and catra i'm literally paying u and doing ur laundry for the rest of the year u better cooperate

catra

[mage sent]

glimmer

that'll do

Adora giggles ~~a~~ small, tiny thing, that makes something familiar bubble in Catra's chest ~~w~~hen she presses send on a selfie of the two of them. "Do you think they're writing all of this down?"

Catra shrugs. "Entrapta probably is." Then, her phone buzzes again, and Catra considers blocking both Entrapta and Glimmer for a moment before she sees who it is.

scorpia

hey i just heard about what happened and

scorpia

honestly

scorpia

i'm kinda laughing a lot

catra

good to know my misery brings u joy

scorpia

sorry it's just. i know you, and this situation, it just must have been funny. i can't believe they actually convinced u

They didn’t convince her to do anything. She was perfectly content with not doing shit for anyone, and then one look from Adora followed by her asking if she would be fine with it was all it took for Catra to comply.

scorpia

anyway, are you okay though? because…

scorpia

well, i know you’ve been avoiding her for a long time

Catra sighs. Out of everyone, Scorpia and Perfuma know the most about what happened two years ago~~on~~ly because in the hours during the aftermath, when Catra had shown up tired and crying at their apartment, she’s pretty sure she spewed out at least a little bit of what happened before passing out. She doesn't think Adora told anyone, because Perfuma and Scorpia have mentioned that no one has talked to them about it. Still, even they don’t know much~~C~~atra doesn’t even think they know about the feelings, just that Catra had gone over to Adora’s that night, and it had felt like she left without her heart afterwards.

She hesitates before she types again.

catra

it’s fine

catra

i was reluctant at first, but i’m okay now

catra

bargained a pretty good deal out of glimmer

scorpia

okay.

scorpia

just keep in mind that you don’t have to do this

scorpia

and if adora does something to make you that upset again…

catra

it’ll be fine, scorpia. i’ll see you in a few hours.

Catra takes a deep breath, and then sets her phone down. Next to her, Adora is scrolling through her own phone, but when she sees

Catra put hers down, she does the same.

"Uh, do you have a spare toothbrush or anything?" she questions. "I feel kind of gross."

In the tiny bathroom —which doesn't really make a difference because they sort of have to be close anyway —they wash up, brushing their teeth and washing their faces. Luckily, they don't have many issues with dominant hands;Catra being left handed and Adora being right apparently comes in handy here, because it's Catra's right and Adora's left that are cuffed. While they brush their teeth and splash their faces, their hands sort of dangle uselessly by their sides.

"The metal keeps digging into my wrist every time you relax," Adora tells her. "I don't think Glimmer and Entrapta thought this through when they put two people with as big of a height difference as us together."

"As big of a— Adora, you're like two inches taller than me."

"I'm half a foot taller than you at the *least."*

"Irrelevant."

Adora laughs, and Catra's chest warms.

(It's horrifying to think about where this could be leading.)

-

hours three through four.

"So, like, we don't have to be ready to meet Scorpia and Perfuma for lunch till two."

"W ait, seriously? *That* late?"

"Y eah, why?"

"W ell I figured we could go to the gym before my hockey practice, but it's also at five, so we probably won't have time."

"Sucks to be you then."

"How about we go now?"

"Ugh, *now?* Can't we like, lay around for a while first?"

"Fine."

"…

"Y ou want me to skip my practice, but you can't just reschedule lunch?"

"No. I've rescheduled like twice already . Plus, I've really been craving this place."

"Okay ."

"Okay?"

"Since you're clearly still looking for an excuse to go back to sleep, how about we just watch TV for a while?"

"Do you see a TV in here?"

"Oh."

"Oh?"

"You're a flop Catra."

"I'm a *flop?"*

"Yeah."

"Who the fuck even says that."

"Me."

"And you don't own a TV either!"

"Eh, shoot."

"Now would you be quiet so I can put Netflix on my laptop to keep you entertained while I try to take a power nap?"

"To keep me entertained? I'm not a child!"

"Sure do act like it sometimes."

"— *Catra!"*

"Shh, the movie is starting."

Adora's pretty sure she's five seconds away from self-combustion.

Catra is leaning on her. *Catra* is leaning on her. They're laying in Catra's twin sized bed that's only really meant for one person, the laptop is sitting on Adora's legs so she can watch (as a form of *entertainment;* Adora rolls her eyes every time she thinks about it), and their arms and legs are brushing and the cold metal of the handcuffs is barely even noticeable and everything is warm because *Catra is leaning on her.*

She, predictably, fell asleep less than ten minutes into the movie. The *problem* is that her head progressively began to fall before it fell all the way onto Adora's shoulder. Now she's making small, quiet snuff noises every time she exhales, and she's cuddly and soft and her head is on Adora's shoulder and Adora's arm is sort of starting to lose its circulation because of the weight but there is absolutely *no* way she's moving from this position.

Oh my God, Adora thinks. *Oh my God, why did I think being handcuffed to her for an entire day would be a good idea?*

They haven't been this close in *years,* and yes, Adora has missed it so much, but now she's also internally panicking because of it.

Something happens in the movie;there' s a loud noise that almost startles Adora out of her thoughts. She holds her breath when she feels Catra shift for a moment, and then releases it when Catra simply slumps further into her.

Yeah. She's so screwed.

hours five through six.

"So," Adora awkwardly starts.

"So"…

Neither one of them moves. There's been a bit of an awkward tension between them ever since Catra woke up, leaned up, and then mumbled a quiet *sorry, how long was I asleep?*

(Two hours. She was asleep for nearly *two hours,* right there on Adora's shoulder. After the movie had finished, Adora had just sat

there, staring at the blank screen with the thoughts *oh my God what do I do what do I do* playing on a loop in her head.)

"I think I can slide my shirt through the cuff f?" Catra finally starts. Her hair is a bit of a mess; it's shorter than what it was when they were younger, but longer than the months after *that* night, when Catra had spontaneously cut all of her hair off with absolutely no warning and kept it like that for a while before she decided to grow it out again. Her eyes are sleepy, and she sounds like she's still waking up. Adora wants to wrap her up in her arms and never let go.

"We don't have to go to the gym, you know," she softly murmurs, suddenly feeling like she'll do anything Catra asks of her. "We can just stay here, and you can go back to sleep until lunch. I know waking up at eight in the morning probably like, totally fucked up your sleeping schedule."

Catra flashes a glance at her; she looks amused, but also...tender? Adora thinks it's a pretty big step up considering she was convinced Catra hated her a few hours ago. She's starting to think that maybe she never did, but in her defense, it was hard to tell, considering Catra basically goes out of her way to avoid her all the time. "It didn't mess it up *that* badly, I'm usually up before noon anyway. And I'm okay now. That nap helped."

Adora flashes her a teasing smile. "So the only reason you were so grumpy this morning was because you didn't get all of your beauty sleep?"

Catra rolls her eyes. "I'm always mean."

But you're also so sweet, Adora thinks. *You're so kind and sweet and you have the biggest heart.*

"Anyway," Catra interrupts her thoughts, "we can go to the gym. I'm sure it'll bother you for days if we disrupt your weekly schedule." Adora's not going to bother arguing that fact because Catra is right. "After I get this shirt of f, I think I could just put on another t-shirt, and

wear a coat half on again. I don't know what to do about your sweatshirt, though."

"I kind of figured I wouldn't be able to change out of it," Adora admits, "so I brought a strapless bra to just slide on underneath."

"Smart," Catra mutters, and then, because apparently she *does* still have evil tendencies, says, "and we could always just cut it off."

"What?" Adora asks in disbelief, quickly wrapping her non-cuffed arm around herself in a sense of protection. "No. This is like, my *favorite* hoodie."

Catra stares at it for a moment. Admittedly, it's a pretty standard hoodie ~~a~~ sleeveless red and white, with the company's name embroidered on the front. It's over three years old, but Adora's managed to keep it in relatively good condition. "What happened to not being able to get away with wearing these types of clothes in a garden restaurant?"

"I'm sure I'll be fine with my hoodie," Adora points out, "but you're still wearing my stained t-shirt and pajama pants, so clearly, you won't."

"Fine," Catra grumbles. "Fine, I'll just. I'll just slip this off, and then put on another t-shirt." There's a moment of silence, and then Catra begins to pull off her t-shirt. Adora's eyes widen, before she quickly spins around before she's caught staring and does something stupid.

Apparently it's a little difficult to take off your shirt with only one hand, but by the time Catra somehow maneuvers it off and onto the arm cuffed with Adora's, she sounds frustrated.

"Can you like—" Adora starts to turn around, and then immediately regrets it when she realizes Catra is shirtless and her boobs are *right there,* even if she's wearing a bra, and her stomach is toned despite the fact that she doesn't even workout, and ~~like~~, lift your arm so it's easier to do this?"

Adora's mind goes blank, caught somewhere between *Catra?* and *soft?* and *friends?,* only to snap back into awareness when she feels the metal bite into her skin. She blinks and finds Catra staring at her with a bit of annoyance in her gaze, tugging on the cuff.

"Lift your arm," she repeats. Adora complies, and after a bit more struggling (Adora would offer to help but she's also decided it would be in her best interest to turn back around before she's *really* caught staring), Catra finally seems to succeed in getting her shirt off, because she lets out a small noise of victory before she tugs Adora in the relative direction of her closet.

It's the same process in reverse in order for Catra to get her shirt on, and by the time she's finished, Adora's pretty sure they've been standing here for nearly twenty minutes.

"*God,* this day is fake," Catra eventually mutters. Adora hears the sound of what seems to be her shoving her pants down; after a moment, she decides she may as well change her pants to the joggers she brought with her too.

"It's been kind of interesting in my opinion," Adora admits. They've only been at this for three hours, and sure, it's been pretty inconvenient at times (namely Catra falling asleep on her and causing her heart to nearly beat out of its chest), but this is also her first time truly hanging out with Catra since...well, since *that* night. She's really, *really* missed her, and finds it quite endearing to know that deep down, Catra's still the same person, even if there are little things that have changed.

"Didn't know taking half an hour to change was interesting to you, princess," Catra huffs, and Adora releases a soft breath at the mention of the old nickname. She has to use both of her hands to slide her bra on, which results in Catra's fingers grazing against her bare skin. Causes Adora to squeeze her eyes shut and think, *Jesus.* "Are you ready?"

"Yeah," Adora whispers. "I'm ready."

-

catra

i’m going to fuckign kill yyou

glimmer

i’m delighted

entrapta

What’s happening?

catra

your both DEAD tp me

entrapta

You’re*

glimmer

if u could let us know what you’re doing that would help

catra

no fuck u

Catra take a minute to pause, takes a breath, and then clicks out of her messages with Entrapta and Glimmer and over to her messages with Scorpia.

catra

hhelp

scorpia

what’s wrong?

catra

aem

scorpia

?

catra

arm

scorpia

?

catra

ARM IN MY FACE

scorpia

should i pass my phone to perfuma? will she be able to understand better?

catra

BCEP

catra

BUCEP

catra

BUCQ

scorpia

hey catra, it’s perfuma

scorpia

are you trying to say bicep?

catra

YES

catra

ADORAS BICEP

catra

IN MY FACE

scorpia

are you guys at the gym?

“Catra?” Adora asks, setting the weight down and then sitting up, and—and she’s fucking sweaty and her arms are straining and

Catra misses the days where she didn't have meltdowns over how hot Adora is. "Are you okay?"

"Fine," Catra forces out from her place of sitting next to the bench. "I'm fine."

"Are you sure?" Adora grabs the water bottle sitting next to her, unscrews the lid, asks "you look kind of red, but you haven't been doing anything, right?" and then drinks the water. A few beads fall from her lips and run down her jaw to her neck, and Catra can't fucking do this.

"It's just hot in here," is all Catra answers with, because she's pretty sure it *has* gotten a lot hotter in here in the span of half an hour. When they first got here, Adora spent a while stretching, hopped on the treadmill like a fit person would (and even attempted to coax Catra into trying the treadmill since running is the only form of workout Catra doesn't flat out refuse to do) and now they're here as Adora works her fucking arms which have definitely gotten bigger over the past couple of years. They've gotten numerous weird looks because of the handcuffs, but the words *social experiment* come out of their mouths without much thought now every time someone passes by and flashes a look at them.

"Oh," Adora responds, and then because she's, unlike Catra, actually a nice and considerate person, she says: "want to go stand outside for a little bit?"

"No, I—" Catra takes a breath. It's not like she can look *away* from Adora's arms, considering she has to stare at her to know when to lift her own arm. "I'm fine. Just.just keep doing what you're doing so we can get this over with."

Adora still looks skeptical, but she nods. She lifts her arms to redo her ponytail, which has since become a bit messy, and Catra *cannot believe* she hadn't noticed how much bigger Adora's arms have gotten. Because~~yes~~, she's been a bit busy trying to avoid her in

the first place, but still, this should be like a *crime* or something. Adora's arms have always been pretty muscular, but *this*—

"Y ou sure you're okay?" Adora asks once she gets settled on the bench again. She's turning her head to face Catra, and her hair is sticking to her forehead because of her sweat and one of her two arms that are starting to make Catra wonder if Adora could bench press her is *right there*—

"I'm fine," Catra repeats, tightening her grip on her phone just to give herself something to do. "Just dandy ."

"Um," Adora starts, a little under an hour later . It's just past one-thirty , Adora seems fairly pleased with all she's managed to accomplish here while being handcuffed, and Catra feels like she's going to pass out at any second now.

("Are you sure you're okay?" Adora had asked when she had finished up; she pressed the back of her hand to Catra' s forehead, and Catra wanted to scream. "Y ou're not sick. Why are you so red?"

"I'm always red," Catra had grumbled after swatting Adora' s hand away. Adora had frowned in response, but Catra had ignored it.)

"What?" Catra questions. They're standing by the doors of the gym; Adora had randomly stopped walking just before they got outside.

"I.uh." she trails of f a bit, and now *her* cheeks look red. Catra narrows her eyes.

"What, Adora?"

"Bathroom," Adora squeaks. Catra stares at her for a moment in disbelief.

"Are you serious?"

"It's not my fault! I always drink a lot when I go to the gym!"

Catra continues to stare at her for a moment, runs a hand through her hair, and then laughs incredulously because she cannot *believe* what her life has led to.

Thankfully, the women's bathroom is empty, and the cubicle is small. They make it work by deciding not to close the door all the way so Catra can slide her arm between that and the wall; she keeps it closed for the most part with her other hand, and glares at her reflection in the mirror because this has to be among the top ten stupidest things (and she's done *a lot* of stupid things before) she's done in her entire life.

"Hurry up," Catra mutters, leaning her head against the door. "This is hurting my arm."

"I'm trying!" Adora exclaims, and Catra would make fun of how high pitched her voice is if this wasn't inconvenient for both of them, "can you just, like, be quiet for a moment? This is super stressful."

"Just fucking pee, Adora. It's not that difficult."

"I can't just—"

Someone walks into the bathroom and freezes upon seeing them. Catra knows Adora must have heard because of the heavy swinging of the door.

"Social experiment," is all Catra says. The person stares at them for a moment, and then turns around and walks straight back out. Catra doesn't blame them.

"Are you done?"

"No."

"Oh for *fuckssake."*

Adora's quiet. Catra sighs, squeezes her eyes shut, and then before she can really think about it, begins to sing. Loud and off-key; something she rarely does because she *has* a nice voice, thank you very much, and there's no reason for her to embarrass herself like this, but if embarrassing herself is what it's going to take for Adora to feel more comfortable, then so be it.

And thankfully, it seems like it's working. Adora laughs from the other side of the door, and then after a few moments, joins in when she recognizes the song, just as off-key. Catra lifts her head to stare at her reflection again, and keeps singing. She wonders where she'd be right now if she had never met Glimmer or Entrapta. Definitely not handcuffed and singing off-key in a public women's restroom.

It's a weird, weird day.

"Are we getting food now?" Adora asks once they've finally left the gym, and she sounds cheerful now. "I'm *starving."*

"When are you not?" Catra grumbles. Adora playfully nudges her — first with her shoulder, and then hand to hand — and without really thinking about it, Catra lets herself intertwine their fingers. Just so the handcuffs won't be as noticeable, is what she tells herself.

Six hours done, eighteen left, Catra thinks. If she can get through being at the gym with Adora's biceps bulging in her face for an hour *and* whatever the fuck that bathroom situation just was, surely she can get through the remainder of the time without much trouble.

*

Chapter End Notes

buckle up my friends bc next chapter is going to be fun

hours seven through twelve

Chapter Notes

> sorry for the wait on this one. i've recently watched arcane and being (slightly) obsessed with one couple while you're still fully obsessed with another at the same time has never happened to me

See the end of the chapter for more notes

hours seven through eight.

"So," Perfuma starts just as Adora and Catra get settled in the two vacant chairs opposite from her. "Are you two used to the cuffs yet?"

Catra stares at her as if to say *seriously?*, and then opens a menu to skim through it. "No."

"I think it's going better than we thought it would," Adora informs her honestly. "Catra's been pretty cooperative about it all."

"I'm this close to just laying on the floor and making you drag me around," Catra says without looking up from the menu.

"I think it'd be easier to just pick you up at that point," Adora teases, nudging her arm. Catra stares at her with wide eyes for a moment — there's a flash of *something* that Adora can't quite read ~~,~~ before she goes back down to her menu. Adora grabs a menu for herself, and then glances at Scorpia, who has yet to say anything. She's staring between Adora and Catra sort of suspiciously, but when Catra flashes her a look, it disappears.

The waiter comes over a couple of minutes later and asks them if they're ready to order. Adora's ready to inform him of exactly what

she wants when Perfuma shakes her head and says, "No, we're still waiting on the rest of our party."

Admittedly, that catches Adora off guard. Catra seems to be feeling the same way, because she jerks her head up from her menu, eyes wide. "We're still waiting on *who* now?"

The question is answered when Mermista and Sea Hawk seemingly appear out of thin air, settling into the two chairs adjacent and opposite to Catra. Adora supposes she put too much faith in Scorpia and Perfuma when she assumed the only reason they got a table this big was so she and Catra could sit side by side without any problems.

"What the fuck are you doing here," Catra bites out, and now she's glaring at everyone sitting at the table. Adora doesn't know whether or not she should be scared.

"Wow," Mermista laughs, immediately pulling her phone out of her pocket to snap a picture of them. "So they weren't joking. You really *are* handcuffed together."

"Who's they?" Adora asks before Catra can retort something bitter, because Adora's come to recognize the pinch in her brows and the way she just barely tenses as what she does before she says something laced in frustration. It's happened a lot in the past several hours.

"Glimmer and Entrapta," Sea Hawk answers cheerfully, hands intertwined in front of him. "They told us about it, Glimmer said you'd be coming here to eat lunch today, and my dear Mermista didn't want to pass up the opportunity to see you stuck in this unfortunate situation."

"Did you know they were coming?" Catra jabs a finger in Scorpia's direction, who lifts her hands in surrender.

"I swear I didn't. I'm just as surprised as you are."

“Anyway , I wasn’t about to pass up the opportunity to laugh at you both, so, here we are,” Mermista shrugs, and then flags down the waiter to order.

Adora orders for both her and Catra, because Catra looks like she’s ready to flip a table or saw off her hand with one of the knives that’s given to them in their cutlery set. Mermista takes a couple more pictures after they order, and Perfuma tries to create peace when Catra inevitably threatens to smash her phone and then Mermista says something about Catra being the smallest one here and how that therefore makes her the least threatening.

When her phone buzzes in her back pocket, Adora doesn’t hesitate on taking it out because the only people who aren’t involved in the near fight that’s probably about to break out is herself and Scorpia, and there’s always been a bit of an awkward tension between them that they’ve never really managed to shake.

Glimmer

mermista sent me some pictures

Glimmer

looks like u guys are having fun over there!

Adora

I’m kind of scared Catra’s going to cut off her hand and run away

Entrapta

That would surely cause some unexpected results, but I suppose it could work

Glimmer

speaking of catra could u tell her to unblock me

Adora laughs for a moment. The commotion around the table has calmed, which is to say that no one looks like they're about to kill anyone anymore.

Adora

I think I'm on her good side right now, so I'll have to refrain from doing that for at least half an hour.

"Also, you know this place is a garden restaurant, right?" Adora tunes back in to hear Mermista say. "And garden restaurants tend to be on the fancier side of things? Because you two look like you've been dragged through a hedge backwards. Have you considered showering?"

"In case you haven't noticed, we're kind of *immobilized* and *incapable* of doing that," Catra snaps, but honestly , Adora doesn't blame Mermista for saying that. She typically tends to shower in the mornings because she goes to the gym straight away;obviously she wasn't able to do that today, and Catra has looked on the disheveled side since the moment she woke up. Adora thinks it's unfair that she still somehow manages to make it look so good on herself. "Don't you have anything better to do then be here and make fun of us?"

"Nope," Mermista says, popping the *p.* "Cleared my schedule for this, but so far, it's been worth it."

There's a bit more bickering between Catra and Mermista, Perfuma and Scorpia eventually start doing that thing where they let everyone within a fifteen foot radius know that they're dating because of how lovingly they stare at each other, and Adora tunes out for the majority of it all. The thought of showering with Catra has come up exactly twice today, and it still only serves to make her feel as hot as she did before. She truly doesn't know what she was thinking upon being the one to suggest they go through with the social experiment.

After having spaced out for a while, Adora doesn't think it's totally unreasonable when she jumps in surprise at the feeling of something pressing into her arm. When she turns to face that direction, she sees Catra leaning into her, lips pulled downward into a frown.

"You were right," she mutters, and she's so quiet that Adora has to lean impossibly closer. Close enough that she can feel Catra's breath on her, can see the flecks of hazel in her left eye. She probably shouldn't be thinking about that. "I should've canceled. I'm regretting this."

"Well the food sounded good, and I'm pretty hungry, so," Adora chuckles in an attempt to lighten the mood. "I don't regret it."

For a moment, Catra looks surprised. She stares at Adora for a beat, and it's so intense that Adora has to avert her eyes, staring at the small, empty glass plate in front of her. She can still feel Catra's eyes burning into the side of her face.

"You don't?" is all she says, and somehow, Adora understands.

Somehow, she understands that Catra is referring to the entire thing, not just the restaurant portion. Suddenly, the music and chatter within the building and the other patrons at their table that are no longer paying attention to them seems to fade to the background. Adora feels like her blood is rushing in her ears in the same way that

only happens when she's doing something exhilarating. She's not sure why it's happening now.

"I don't," Adora echoes.

"Why?"

Things Adora wants to say: *Because I've missed you. Because I've never stopped wanting my best friend back. Because I just want to spend time with you, but you'll never allow it. Because no matter what I do, I always make things worse. Because it's been two years since everything was okay, and I still love you.*

Things Adora does say: "Because...because I've missed you."

There's no response. When Adora turns back to face her, she sees Catra staring at her with an unreadable expression.

There's a long beat where neither one of them speaks. The blood in Adora's ears sounds louder than ever.

Then, just as Catra parts her lips to speak, the waiter reappears with their food. He sets a plate down in front of Catra, in front of Adora, and then in front of the rest of the occupants of the table.

Just like that, the moment vanishes.

-

Lunch is wonderful. Catra has never felt so content and fulfilled in her entire life. She thinks that maybe this should become a weekly getup; her and Adora, handcuffed and sat far closer than normal, along with Mermista, Sea Hawk, Perfuma, and Scorpia.

(Hence the sarcasm.)

Admittedly, it isn't *that* bad. The food is pretty great (Catra wouldn't be here if it wasn't), and after Mermista's quota for making fun of them is reached, they actually talk about other things. They talk about the fact that semester finals are next week, and how all of them are collectively procrastinating studying. Scorpia informs them that their apartment is like a living greenhouse because of all the new plants Perfuma brought in a few days ago. Adora tells them, matter-of-factly, that she has a game next week that they're totally going to win. Mermista tells her she'll be at the underground showcase both Sea Hawk and Catra will be singing at on Wednesday.

There's something that's shifted between her and Adora, and… Catra doesn't know what to call it. Nor does she know if it was a good or bad change, but as of now, it's still a *change* which means it's *different,* and anything related to change has always made Catra a bit anxious.

"Hey ," Adora suddenly reaches for her hand and squeezes, and Catra blinks as she seemingly stumbles out of her stupor. She thinks then, that it wasn't the first time that Adora had said her name. "Are you okay? You've been out of it for a while."

Catra scoffs. *You just admitted to having missed me for God knows how long despite the fact that you didn't want me like I wanted you* is what she thinks. "I'm fine. Just wondering how the hell we're supposed to get through your practice while handcuffed," is what she says, because to be honest, that's been a lingering worry in the back of her mind for a while now.

Whereas Adora looked hesitant before, she looks pretty amused now. "We'll be fine. I promise."

I promise.

Something clenches in Catra's chest;an aching, painful feeling reminding her of the last time Adora said those words to her. The only difference is that this is *now;* this is the present, and Adora is staring at her with big blue eyes that are full of sincerity and delight.

"Okay ," Catra quietly says. "Okay ."

There's a flash Catra is momentarily blinded by, followed by the sound of a camera going off. Perfuma lowers her phone just as Catra turns to look at her.

"It was a sweet moment," is all she says in explanation, nodding to their still intertwined hands above the table. Catra stiffens, and then immediately pulls her hand away. "And Entrapta requested we provide any noticeable changes from being annoyed and infuriated with each other.'"

"Not you too," Adora mumbles. Catra' s eye twitches, and then she leans forward to eat the last of her shrimp skewer.

"So this was fun," Mermista declares a few minutes later as Sea Hawk fishes a few bills on the table to pay for their food;apparently they have places to be and all that. "I definitely wouldn't be opposed to doing this again sometime."

"W e get lunch as a group pretty often though?" Scorpia points out, but it comes out more like a question. Catra agrees. The only difference is that usually Glimmer, Bow, and Entrapta are here too; plus, she and Adora are sitting on opposite ends of the table rather than elbow to elbow due to being handcuffed.

"I meant with T weedledee and Tweedledum over here," Mermista motions to both Catra and Adora, "because what they're stuck in really did make my day."

She flounces off before Catra can spit out the snarky remark she has lined up;Sea Hawk is left standing in her wake, only to quickly follow when Catra's glare finds him. Scorpia and Perfuma leave after the

rest of them have paid (and after making sure to wish them luck), and once she and Adora are left alone, Catra stares down at her empty plate.

"Glimmer said to tell you to unblock her ," Adora says from next to her.

"Maybe later ," Catra mumbles wearily .

hour nine.

They call an uber to take them back first to Catra's dorm so she can grab her old skates, and then to Adora's apartment because of the fact that they have less than an hour to be ready to go, and walking back to both of their places will take up at least half of that time. Glimmer and Entrapta are no longer there —thankfully —and Adora simply grabs a few things she'll need for practice before they make the drive to the *Bright Moon University Ice Arena,* as Adora makes a big show of calling it.

"So, like, explain to me," Catra says in the back of the car;the woman who's driving them looked a little worried upon seeing their handcuffs, but they had made the usual *social experiment* statement and she had looked slightly less afraid. "I don't mean to be crude, but how the *hell* are we supposed to do this?"

"You can still ice skate, right?" Adora asks, and Catra's just taken aback by the fact that Adora looks both calm and confident.

"I mean—I haven't done it in a while, but I guess it's not just something you forget."

"Great," Adora smiles. "So, I'll explain the situation to my coach — she's pretty chill, so she probably won't have any issues with it —

and we'll just have to make the most of the situation. I'm sure we'll get the hang of it."

"Adora, I appreciate how confident and sure of yourself you can be at times," Catra sighs, "but this just sounds like a recipe for disaster."

"Catra," Adora says, voice unwavering. "We'll be fine. We'll be better then fine. Stop worrying so much."

"Stop worrying? You know, someday I'm going to record you and have you play your voice back to yourself. Can't believe the professional worrier herself just told *me* to stop worrying."

"I'm sure whatever bad impression you do of me will get the message across." The car stops then, and Adora grabs her bag and Catra's hand. Catra thinks she likes this alternative as opposed to just tugging on the cuffs. "Now come on, let's go."

Catra follows Adora into the locker room, and almost immediately thinks her regret for this thing is going to reach its peak fairly soon. It's a bit crowded, so she tries her best to simply follow Adora and stay out of the way. The only other person she knows on the team is Lonnie, who pointedly looks at their connected arms with a *wtf?* expression until Adora greets most of the team and explains the handcuffs.

Catra doesn't know any of Adora's other teammates, so she sort of uselessly hangs on her side as Adora attempts to maneuver around and put her gear on. She uses Catra's t-shirt trick to get her jersey on, and then opens her locker to pull out the rest of the gear.

"Damn," Catra breathes, "you have to put on all of *that?"*

"Safety first," Adora shrugs, and then adds, "and one of our members is, coincidentally, out because of an injury, and lucky for you, she's also pretty small." Catra bristles at the notion of her size. "I already messaged her to ask if you could borrow her gear."

"Her *what?"*

"Her"—

"No, I heard you, I just—I'm not here to play hockey or something, what the fuck?"

"Of course not," Adora tells her as she straps on her things. Catra supposes it's a good thing they got here a bit early, because this is taking longer than what it probably usually would. "You're not gonna have a stick or pants or anything fancy, just the helmet and pads," she waves her hand dismissively, "which you honestly aren't even going to need because we're just running drills today. It won't be too difficult."

"Right," Catra mutters weakly. Next to her, Lonnie laughs and says *if I was in your situation, I would've just skipped, but I guess that's the difference between me and Adora,* and then leaves. "Not too difficult."

hours ten through eleven.

"I'm going to die," Catra concludes once the door to the rink swings open with a *clash* nearly ten minutes later. There are already a few people warming up on the ice, and Catra is fairly certain it's over for her. "I'm going to die, and I want Glimmer, Entrapta, *and* you to cover the costs of my funeral."

"Wait, me too?" Adora turns to look at her with a pout. She's carrying her helmet in one hand and her stick in the other, her ponytail is up neat, and Catra can tell she's getting into her serious mode.

"Yes, you," Catra hisses. "Because you're the one who decided to get into hockey when you were younger and now we're *here,* and all I can say is you're lucky I like you because if I didn't, I would *not* be doing all of this."

Adora freezes then, and Catra is confused for all of four seconds before she realizes what she's just admitted.

"I-I mean you're lucky I tolerate you," she quickly defends herself. "Because-because I don't really tolerate anyone, and if I was handcuffed to like anyone else I definitely wouldn't have put up with putting all of this shit on me -I probably wouldn't have put up with practically *anything* we've done today -except with a few exceptions I guess, and" Catra trails off, a bit out of breath and starting to realize why Adora always starts rambling nonsense whenever she's nervous.

(She thinks, every time Adora does it, no matter how many times Catra tries to convince herself it's *annoying* and *trying* and quite frankly a waste of time while it happens because Adora's too nervous to tell her the thing she's clearly trying to avoid, it's a little bit of an adorable habit of hers.)

"For what it's worth, I like you too," Adora eventually murmurs, staring at something in front of her for a slight moment before she turns to meet Catra's eyes. "That's why I" she pauses to take a breath. "I've just really missed you. And I do appreciate you for putting up with all of this, and I *do* think we can do it."

Catra swallows heavily. *She's so beautiful,* she thinks. *And she works hard for the things she cares about.* Her heart thuds dangerously, beats that sound like *did you really ever think you were over her?*

Shut up, Catra tells herself. *I was. Am.*

"There is no I like you *too,* because I don't even like you," Catra mumbles.

Yesterday, she might have been able to say that and make it sound believable. Today, Adora just snorts and says, "okay . Are you ready?"

"I don't know ," Catra sighs.

"That' s the spirit!" Adora cheers despite her words, and Catra follows her onto the ice. She's a bit shaky at first; Adora even hovers next to her to make sure she's alright, but memory and instinct seem to kick in after a few seconds because she manages to keep herself balanced. She follows Adora off to one of the sides and toward a tall looking woman who is standing with her back to them.

The first thing Catra notices about the woman, when she turns around, is that she's insanely beautiful. She radiates warmth and welcoming, from her gentle smile to the way her eyes scrunch ever so slightly that lets Catra know she must be genuine. The explanation goes, in all honesty, a lot smoother than Catra thought it would be. She knows Adora said the coach would be chill about it, but this is a little *too* chill if you ask her.

"Got a little too wild at a party and woke up like this?" she asks sympathetically. "That happened to me a few times in college."

"I.a. few times?" Catra can't help but ask. Then the woman turns toward her, and because her smile seems to have the radiance of a thousand suns when she lifts her hand for Catra to shake, she sort of forgets her question.

"Mara," she easily introduces herself. "Ring leader of this little gang."

Catra's a little confused because Mara doesn't really look all that older than them, but she doesn't question it. "Catra," she says

simply, and then adds, "social experiment," just for good measure.

"Social experiment, huh?" Mara asks, nodding to the handcuffs. "Sounds fun."

"Yeah," Catra grumbles. "Fun."

The push Adora gives her is good-natured, and Mara lets out a hearty laugh. "Oh, come on. I'm sure it'll be fine. I know you're not a beginner when it comes to ice skating."

Catra frowns for a moment, is about to ask how the hell Mara would even know that, before Adora clears her throat a little too loudly for her liking.

Mara shares a look with Adora that Catra can't read ~~it~~ 's then that Catra realizes, after looking back at Adora, that Adora's cheeks are a warm shade of red ~~a~~nd they seem to sort of have a stand off match of intense staring before Mara eventually says, "well, alright then. It's a good thing Saturday practices are light, because we're just gonna run some drills before we get out of here. Only do the parts that you can, okay? I don't want either one of you getting hurt."

Catra only half-processes what Mara just told them because she's still trying to decode both the look she and Adora just shared and figure out how Mara has clearly somehow heard about her, but then Mara is skating away from them and blowing on a whistle that gathers the rest of the team's attention, signaling the start of practice. Adora, after flashing a questioning look in Catra's direction and giving a bit of a tug on the handcuffs, follows with Catra in suit.

It's a bit of a struggle at first. Well, okay, Catra figures that's a major understatement. It's an *extreme* struggle at first;they collide into each other multiple times when Adora tries to turn too fast or makes a sudden movement, and there's a bit of profanity used when Catra almost falls onto her ass after stumbling into the cones they have set up for one of the drills they're running. They fumble for each other both times the other nearly falls (which is mostly Adora fumbling for

Catra when she slips because they're *both* going down if one of them does), but there's one time Adora almost falls when she does a sudden move that she can't quite complete with their situation and Catra simply stands there before she realizes Adora's about to go down and has to throw her arm out to try and balance her.

They… *somewhat* make it work by keeping their arms lifted straight out from one-another so they don't have to be as close and therefore have less of a chance of bumping into each other, which is the main cause of all of the falling anyway. What it does mean is that Adora has to use one hand when it comes to actually maneuvering her stick, but Catra thinks they both prefer that then the constant running into each other. There's a quick drill the team runs where they have to work in groups of three, and Adora sort of sticks to the outskirts which makes sense because they're basically a danger to themselves and everyone else who comes near them.

Mara –and the two assistant coaches, one of which introduces herself as Netossa –give the team inspirational talks every so often in between the drills they're running, and make sure to tell both Adora and Catra that they're doing a good job making the most of their situation. Netossa and a few of Adora's teammates also make fun of them, but it's lighthearted in the way that tells Catra that the team really does seem to work as a family.

"I asked Netossa to record us for a few things," Adora admits when Catra narrows her eyes upon spotting the phone in the other woman's hands. When Catra stares at Adora in confusion, Adora tries to make a motion with her hand, which doesn't really work because neither one of her hands are unoccupied. "Cause Glimmer asked us to film a few things for the project."

"You really are taking this whole thing seriously, huh?" Catra asks, watching as Adora pulls off her helmet to down some water, and then passes the bottle for Catra to do the same. She's not really doing that much physical exertion aside from just following Adora around, but considering Glimmer was right to point out the fact that

the only form of workout she does nowadays is walking to her classes, this is tiring her out more than she cares to admit.

"Well, if it was for my project, I'd probably want the same done for me," Adora points out. Catra snorts.

"You're admitting that you'd handcuff people for a school project?" she questions, and smiles when Adora immediately splutters.

"I— *no,* I'm just saying. If I had to do a social project, I would've just done something like, one of those *can an adult pass a 5th grade test* thing, or something."

"Not to dampen your parade, but that sounds extremely boring."

"Guess that's why Glimmer and Entrapta decided to handcuff us together."

Catra's lips form into a thin line. "Touché."

The second half of practice is a lot smoother than the first. By then, they've sort of familiarized each other with their movements, and… it's nice, Catra will admit. Hanging out and messing with Adora, it's a nice thing to have again. Sure, it's frustrating at times and it makes Catra think *why the fuck did I agree to this,* but all in all, she thinks she might enjoy it. They were best friends at one point, after all. As long as they're ignoring the elephant in the room, they still get along well.

For the most part, Adora tries to remain serious, brows pinched together and jaw clenched as she works the exercises, and Catra tries not to stare directly at her face through her helmet for most of the time because one of the times she nearly fell was after distracting herself by just how concentrated Adora looked, and how attractive it makes her. There are times, however, that it seems to occur to Adora just how bizarre their situation is, and she'll start to laugh at both that and Catra's antics as she tries to make this as easy as possible.

Considering they've only come crashing down once (it was Adora's fault they both landed on their asses is what Catra will repeatedly tell anyone who asks) by the time Mara announces they're gonna wrap it up with a final drill, Catra's considering it a win.

Their performance is quite astounding considering their situation if Catra does say so herself. Mara gathers them up near one end of the ice afterward. One of the kids Adora's begun conversing with says something to make Adora laugh, but it's not the unrestrained, loud laughter Catra hears when they're with their friend group. It makes Catra wonder if Adora is the same with her other college friends as she is with the group. It makes her wonder if these people know her as well as Catra did. If they even know her at all. If they can make her laugh like Catra used to.

There's a bit of cheering that comes from the team, which makes Catra realize she's basically zoned out for the entirety of the inspiring speech the coaches must have given the team. They begin to disperse soon after, and Adora waits until it's less crowded to start moving so they have less of a risk of running into anyone.

And Adora.she looks happy . Both of their helmets are off now, having been taken off and set down when Mara signaled the end of practice, and that means that Catra can see her better than before. She's smiling to herself, and they're skating a bit closer than before, and she's warm in the midst of the ice rink where everything is cold. The bright, fluorescent lights of the rink make the flush from the cold in her cheeks even more visible, and there's hair falling from her ponytail and her eyes are scrunched ever so slightly from her smile, and Catra just can't seem to get over how beautiful she is.

And then, because the universe must *actually* hate her, somehow, despite there being absolutely nothing for her to trip over, Catra feels her foot slip out from beneath her. There's a moment where they both sort of scramble to right themselves after Adora registers what's happening, but all it seems to do is make it worse, because they tumble down onto the ice a second later. Catra lands on her back with a hiss of pain, and Adora lands on top of her with her left hand

next to Catra's head and their handcuffed arms caught sort of awkwardly between their bodies. Catra can feel where Adora's fingers curl into her shirt.

For a moment, it's silent. Catra stares up at Adora, who stares straight back down at her. Their faces are separated by mere centimeters. Adora's chest is heaving against hers. She can hear the breaths they take, can feel that one, or maybe both, of their hearts are racing. Adora's cheeks are even more flushed than they previously were, and Catra imagines she doesn't look all too different.

This is the closest they've been in years, and Adora isn't moving, and for some reason, neither is Catra. Adora is just staring at her with her wide eyes in the way that makes Catra's mind go blank, and when Adora releases another breath, Catra's eyes drop to her lips, but only for a second. When she looks back up at Adora's eyes, she realizes Adora is staring at her own lips for a moment before they flicker back up.

Oh my God, Catra thinks, *what the fuck. What the fuck is happening.*

She's been cold for the entirety of this practice, still wearing the t-shirt she managed to wrangle on earlier, and the feeling of the ice against her back isn't helping, but Adora's weight is warm and comforting on top of her, and she's starting to feel kind of hot now. A part of her is screaming at herself to shove Adora off of her or tell her to move, but the other part is saying things like *I want her to stay* and *she's so warm* and *please don't leave me.*

I want to kiss her, she thinks, most prominently. *I want to kiss her again. I just want* her. *I want—*

And then, before either one of them moves, Mara's voice echoes in the near empty rink. "Are you guys okay?" she calls out, and Catra can just barely make out the indistinguishable sound of ice skates moving closer to them over the sound of her racing heart.

The fingers curled into her shirt feel like they tighten for a moment, before releasing all together. Adora moves off of her, still looking slightly dazed, and Mara appears next to them to use a hand to pull her up to her feet. Catra sits up then, feeling just as lost as Adora looks before she's also pulled to her feet and asked the same question. "Hey, are you two alright?"

"I—nothing comes out of Adora's mouth for a moment, before she sort of gestures weakly. "I'm—I'm okay," she says, almost roughly, and then they both turn to look at Catra as if waiting for her to confirm the same thing.

No, I'm not fucking okay, Catra thinks. *I thought I had finally managed to get over the girl who broke my heart, and I just realized that I'm not. I'm so, so not.*

"Yeah," is all Catra can manage to say. Her back has a dull ache in it, but it's definitely the least of her concerns right now. "I'm good."

Mara's smile is relieved, and then she starts skating toward the exit of the rink, motioning for them to follow. After a moment, they do. "Funny you two managed to avoid any serious falls until after practice was over."

"Yeah," Catra hears Adora say, and her voice still sounds rough and scratchy. She lets out a bit of a nervous laugh. "Ironic."

By the time they've gotten out of the gear, packed everything up, and exited the building, it's close to seven. The sun is setting over the horizon, painting the sky in pretty pastel pinks and reds and yellows, and there's an immensely awkward silence that's filled with even more tension than their walk this morning. They haven't said a single thing to each other since they left the locker room aside from deciding that they'd head back to Adora's apartment. Catra feels like she was hit by a train and dragged for seventeen blocks. Adora took out her ponytail and didn't redo it, so she must be feeling the same way.

Catra's still trying to process what all of this means, what *exactly* everything that she's realized in the past twenty minutes means, when Adora shatters the silence.

"Thanks," she says. Her voice is soft as they stare at the path in front of them, where other college kids occasionally pass them. "For , um, doing all of that." Her voice lowers to a whisper . "I. really appreciate it."

Catra swallows. "Y eah. Um, you're welcome," she forces out, and out of the corner of her eye, she sees Adora turn to look at her.

Fck, is the only thing Catra thinks. *Fck.*

hour twelve.

Catrapta

How was hockey practice?

glimmer

i don't think she unblocked us yet

catra

loved it!

glimmer

nvm

Etrapta

Is she being sarcastic?

glimmer

well it seemed based off of the videos we were sent that she did love it

catra

hm?

Etrapta

Adora sent us some videos a while ago. You looked like you were having fun, taking into account the smile you had on and the fact that you didn’t look as irritated as we thought you would.

catra

oh, ok :)

glimmer

ok now i'm scared

Entrapta

Hmm.

catra

you should be :)

"That actually smells kind of good," Catra tells Adora after she sets her phone down. They've decided to make dinner for themselves before they figure out how the showering situation is going to work — *if* it's going to work because Catra feels gross and sweaty, and she knows Adora definitely feels the same way (if not worse), but she's also starving right now. "What is it?"

"Oh, um, pasta alla vodka," Adora answers, and it's then that Catra realizes she looks a bit shy. "Or, um, something similar to it. I know that I know that you really like it, and I also know you hate cooking, so you might have not had it in a while, and I also just wanted to thank you for going along with my schedule today."

It's a small gesture, but it means that Adora had been thinking of her. That *Adora* is thinking of *Catra* when she decides to make dinner for the both of them after spending the entire day together; that she picked something out that she already knew Catra would enjoy.

"It's nothing," is all Catra can think to mutter after Adora shoots her a curious look. "I mean it wasn't *that* much."

"Yeah, but still," Adora says after using her spoon to stir the noodles in the boiling water for a moment, "I mean—we haven't even *really* done anything for you, and you put up with my stuff even though we—" she trails off a bit, and Catra stares at the space in front of her. *Even though we haven't talked in months?* she thinks, but Adora doesn't finish that particular sentence.

"I was actually going to ask if we could go to the music building after we're done here," Catra tells her. "I've been working on some stuff recently, and I was planning on getting a bit of it done today."

Adora looks at her; her eyelashes flutter, and her cheeks are rosy in the limelight. For a moment, Catra is back in this same apartment two years ago, and there's unpacked boxes filled with furniture and decor all over the place, jazz music playing in the background, and they're dancing together, Adora's hands on her waist, thighs pressed one against another, giggling and faces so close together that Catra can feel Adora's breath against her lips.

"Of course," Adora says in the present, and Catra blinks out of the past.

Her heart stutters like it's forgotten how to beat.

perfuma

so scorpia's phone died, and she wants me to check in on you

perfuma

how did hockey go?

catra

better than i thought, actually

perfuma

wow i know i said you two would be fine but i expected you to say it went worse

catra

it.was, i guess, but adora made it bearable

perfuma

good

perfuma

she’s pretty amazing, isn’t she?

catra

she is

*

Chapter End Notes

happy holidays!

hours thirteen through fifteen

Chapter Notes

> tw for abuse, it's literally a blink and you'll miss it mention but it's still worth noting, as well as nudity and underage drinking (but it's only underage if u live in america)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

hour thirteen.

They've been awkwardly standing in the bathroom for nearly five minutes now, dodging the actual issue. Which is—

"So, um," Adora tries, because Catra hasn't actually spoken since they finished eating. Dinner was nice; it was less awkward than this at least, even if Catra seemed lost in thought for the majority of it. "I—you can—you can go first, if you want."

Catra makes a lame motion to the shower with her non-cuffed hand. "No, you can go first. You probably, um, you know. Got sweatier than I did."

"Probably," Adora laughs nervously, "but—you can actually undress because of your t-shirt, and I uh, still don't know how I'm going to get this hoodie off, so" she trails off, and Catra slowly nods.

"Okay," is all she says, only a little hesitant. "I'll, uh, get in then." And then she's throwing her hair into a messy bun and slipping off her shirt, and Adora's panicking. She wishes she wasn't but she pretty much is, eyes laser-focused on the wall and hyper aware of the fact that Catra is undressing next to her. She makes a few frustrated noises as she maneuvers her shirt off, and then it occurs to Adora that she's taking her bra off too, and she thinks she might actually

jump on board with Catra's whole *I'm going to kill Glimmer and Entrapta* idea because now Catra's next to her and completely bare from the waist up.

Then she hears the sound of pants unzipping, and she swears she's actually going to die.

"Are we actually doing this?" Catra asks, quiet. Adora doesn't blame her; her eyes are squeezed shut now, but she's pretty sure Catra is mostly naked next to her. It wouldn't be the first time she's seen Catra naked, but it would be the first in a really, *really* long time.

"I-If you're uncomfortable, we don't *have* to," Adora whispers, eyes still squeezed shut, "we can just use a wet washcloth to somewhat clean ourselves."

Catra makes a humming noise underneath her breath. "We could. I'd feel a lot better if I could actually shower, though."

"Yeah," Adora mumbles. "Me too."

She hears Catra take a deep breath, followed by the sound of the shower curtain opening and the tug of the chain. Adora opens her eyes, only to stumble over Catra's clothes as she closes the shower curtain. She hears the water turn on, followed by the soft gasp Catra releases from the chill of the water.

"You left your clothes everywhere," Adora comments, despite the fact that she literally doesn't care at all.

"Is it alright if I use your body wash?" Catra asks instead of responding. Adora squeezes her eyes shut *again* because the thought of Catra smelling like her makes that familiar warm and soft feeling Adora gets around her flutter and that's a little inconvenient right now.

"Uh, yeah," she forces herself to say, glancing around her small bathroom. She ends up doing some trophy-worthy leaning and

stretching, reaches for the cabinet that she keeps some washcloths in, before blindly holding it out between the shower curtain and wall. "Here."

"Thanks," Catra murmurs, and it goes silent between them for all of six seconds before the chain is tugged on a bit harder. "Can you come closer? I can't reach"…

Adora's glad Catra can't see her, because she's pretty sure her face is a the same shade as the red hoodie she's been wearing all day. She tries her best to move closer, but soon her arm is in the shower too, and she can't stop thinking about the fact that Catra is *naked* in her shower and she's using her soap and they're only separated by a curtain and a few feet and she doesn't hate Adora ~~ s~~he maybe even *likes* Adora ~~ a~~nd Adora still loves her *so much*—

"Catra, I can't ~~ I~~ can't come any closer ," Adora stutters, leg pressing against the tub when the chain is suddenly tugged on again. The water is streaming down her arm, wetting her hoodie, and it's damp and uncomfortable. "Can you just"—

She flinches when the shower curtain is suddenly pulled aside, the rising steam from the water causing her to blink a few times. Catra is standing there, very wet and very naked, and she stares at Adora for a long beat. Adora watches the line of throat as she swallows thickly, the beads of water running from her neck to her shoulders to her collarbone to her chest and *holy shit*—

"Get in," Catra suddenly says, and Adora' s eyes snap up from her breasts back to her face, still trying to register what exactly is happening as well as how and why it's happening. Catra's face is serious. Adora swallows heavily, heart feeling like it's going to beat out of her chest. She works her mouth to speak, but no matter how hard she tries, nothing comes out.

"~~w~~hat?" is apparently the best she can do.

"It'll be easier if we just—" Catra turns and motions at the shower , and Adora is still trying Very Hard to keep her eyes drilled into her face—together ."

Apparently Adora still can't make out full sentences. "You want to—with me?—"

"God, Adora," Catra snaps, closing the shower curtain. Adora blinks, brows furrowed, and sucks in a deep breath when she realizes she hadn't been breathing for the entirety of that. "Nevermind. You made it weird."

"I made it weird?" Adora exclaims, waving her non-cuffed hand despite the fact that Catra can no longer see her, *"you're* the one who just told me to get in the shower with you!"

"It's not like we haven't seen each other naked before!"

"That was a long time ago! And that was before I—" Adora forces herself to stop right there, face flushed and brows knitted as she stares at her feet. She does *not* need to let something like that slip now.

The shower curtain parts again. Catra is staring at her again, but this time it's more intense, and the air is hotter because more steam is quickly filling the rest of the room.

It's quiet. There are moonlit oceans and silver petals falling into a lake all within Catra's eyes.

"Before you what?" she asks, a lot softer than before.

Adora makes a weak noise in the back of her throat. She feels like she's going to explode. "You..you know what," she murmurs, and she can't seem to break their gaze.

Catra chuckles a bit disbelievingly. "No, I really don't."

She doesn't say anything else, just continues to stare at Adora with the shower open and causing water get everywhere, and Adora snaps.

She takes her phone out of her back pocket and tosses it on the counter, before pulling her socks off. It's a bit of a struggle to get her joggers off with one hand, but she manages, all while with the knowledge that Catra is staring at her.

Calm down, she tells herself after nearly tripping from how quickly she attempted to get her pants off. *Just calm down before you do something stupid again.*

"Look," Catra sighs, and she turns around as much as the cuffs will allow her. There's a bit of water all over the floor now because the curtain is still parted. "I'm not looking. Does that help?"

Adora stares at her shoulder blades, yet another weak noise spilling from her lips. It does help, but not by much, because Adora thinks she's still a little close to becoming hysterical. It takes longer than she'd like to unhook her bra because she has to bunch her hoodie up and use one hand, but she manages. She still doesn't actually know what to do about her hoodie.

"I...my hoodie," she eventually points out, words still a bit jumbled because now she's only wearing that and underwear and there's water all over the floor and the room is very hot and Catra is still right there. "I don't"…

Catra is silent. Adora swallows, nods to herself, thinks *okay,* and then works her hoodie off as far as it can go, leaving it hanging off her arm. She stands there for another few moments, before she eventually decides *fuck it,* and shoves her underwear down her legs. Then she turns to look back at Catra, who's still standing with her back to her;stares at the water dripping down the curve of her spine all the way down to her backside and thinks *we're actually doing this.*

She takes a deep breath. Then another, and then another, in hopes it'll perhaps help with her current inability to form any actual sentences.

"I'm, uh, gonna get in," she whispers, not sure if Catra even actually hears her. She steps in a moment later, and when Catra shifts so she can step underneath the spray of water, she immediately hisses at the burn.

"Sorry," Catra murmurs, and their skin just barely grazes against each other when she moves to make it less hot. "You can turn it up when you want. I'm already used to it."

Because that's what I'm worried about, Adora rolls her eyes. Her hoodie is slowly getting wetter, dragging her arm down, and she's vulnerable and exposed and standing next to the woman she loves who's also vulnerable and exposed. The last thing on her mind is how hot the water is.

Catra looks flustered now too, eyes settling on Adora's chest for a split second before finding the tiled wall behind her. Her jaw is clenched, eyes wide, and she looks incredibly tense.

"What," Adora breathes out. Catra's eyes snap to meet her own, and then she shakes her head. Adora frowns. "Listen, you're the one who wanted to shower with me, so"—

"I didn't *want* to," Catra quickly defends herself, "I just said it'd be easier."

Neither one of them says anything after that for at least fifteen seconds. Catra licks her lips and Adora's gaze drops down to them. She thinks about when they fell on the ice earlier, how it felt to have Catra pinned beneath her. How Catra stared at her lips for the briefest second. How, given a few more seconds, and she might have leaned down to kiss Catra again. How she almost messed things up *again.*

"Let's just," Catra starts, "let's just get this over with."

"Yeah," Adora agrees. "Okay."

She reaches for the body wash, holds it out for Catra to put on her cloth. After, she grabs ahold of her loofah, ignores the slightly teasing jab Catra throws her way for owning a loofah, and then pours the soap on top of it.

It works, for a while. They stand with their backs to each other, not a single word between them, and Adora tries her best to make her mind go blank instead of thinking about the situation she's found herself in as she washes her body. The hoodie is soaked and heavy now, but she can't find it in her to even care.

Eventually she makes the water warmer as it cools down, and is thinking *maybe this will be fine* when Catra suddenly mumbles a quiet "I need to rinse, can I get past?" and Adora thinks, *sure, that's fine,* but it turns out to not be fine because she turns to slide past Catra at the exact moment Catra does and suddenly they're a breath away from each other, warm and soft and naked as water runs down their bodies.

It's ~~it's~~ a lot. It's too much. They're facing each other, bodies a hair away from each other, their height difference forcing Catra to look up at Adora, and Adora is suddenly overcome with the feeling of want.

A want to push Catra against the wall and kiss her senseless, or maybe just cup her cheeks and stroke her skin with the pads of her thumbs and kiss her in a more gentle way as opposed to the way she did two years ago. She wants to hug her, pull her close and meld their bodies together until they lose their breath, wants to hug her every day after this. Wants to fall asleep texting or calling her or even next to her like they used to, wants to hold her hand and whisper words of affirmation into her ear when she gets nervous. Wants to lay her head in her lap as Catra strokes her hair and sings to her because it always calmed her down when she was stressed, wants to never let her go again.

f.” Catra starts, before trailing of f. She pulls her gaze away , and she almost looks like she’s trembling. “Y ou’re using all of the hot water.”

Adora blinks, then pulls herself out of her thoughts. She clears her throat, pushing herself against the wall so that Catra can move past her. “Sorry .”

“It’ s okay,” Catra mumbles, ducking underneath the spray and facing away from her. Adora looks away too;decides to hurry up so they can just get out of here and be done with it.

She can’t do this.

Entrapta [illegible]

How are things?

Glimmer [illegible]

yeah catra was scaring us earlier

Entrapta [illegible]

You mean she was scaring YOU.

Adora [illegible]

We showered

Adora

and peed again

Etrapta

Interesting.

Glimmer

how tf did u two manage to shower

Adora

Did yu guys take swift wind

Etrapta

Yes. He’s here at my apartment

Adora

Ok

Adora

can one of yuo come over an bring a book

Entrapta

When?

Glimmer

um, sure? why?

Adora

So you can ssmash it agaisnt my head killling me instantly

Adora clicks out of her messages with Glimmer and Entrapta and over to her messages with Bow, fingers trembling.

Adora

I cant do this

Bow

What?

Adora

Bow pleas

Adora

Im gonna cry

Adora

I cant do this

Bow

Why are you going to cry?

Bow

did Catra do something?

Bow

What are you two doing? are you okay? do you want me to call you?

Adora

No don’t call

Adora

We just showered

Adora

My hoodies gone

Adora

We had to cut it off after we showered

Bova

Oh, Adora. I’m sorry, I know you liked it

Bova

is.that why you want to cry?

Adora

No

Adora

I don t care about the hoodie

Adora

I cant handle being aruond Catra again knowing tomorrow she’s going to go back to pretending like I don’t exist

Adora

It hurts so much

Bow

I know. I know it must be hard to lose your best friend like that

Adora

its more than that

Bow

what do you mean?

Bow

Waitn

Bow

wait

Bow

you were heartbroken when u two stopped talking

Bow

And u guys were like..really close

Bow

Adora.were u two a thing?Did you like her?

Adora

we werent a thing

Bow

But you liked her?Do still like her?

Adora

bow

Bov

OMG

Bov

YOU like CA TRA?

Adora

More

Bov

YOU LOVE HER,?

Bov

WHY DIDNT I KNOW

Bov

ADORA OH MY GODSJDHFH

Adora

STOP FREAKING OUT

Bov

AHHHHHH

Bov

Ok sorry

Bov

I’m calm

Bov

Not really but

Bov

Ok. Does anyone else know?

Adora

No

Bov

Not even Catra?

Adora

no

Bow

Dang. So today must’ve been harder than I thought

Bow

But what if she likes you too?

Adora

She doesnt

Adora

i already fucked that up

Bow

wait what?

Catra says something that Adora doesn't quite hear from her place next to her on Adora's bed, so Adora quickly shuts off her phone to look at her. She looks so small and soft now, sitting with her legs crossed on the edge of Adora's bed in Adora's shirt and sweatpants that are a little too big on her with Adora's blanket over her shoulders because she had finished getting dressed first and made a comment about how cold it is in the apartment.

She's staring at her with a *look,* one that reminds Adora of the night they got caught walking home in the rain during high school and had to run the rest of the way, laughing and freezing and shivering. It reminds her of the way they pressed together underneath the protection of the balcony, cold and wet with their arms wrapped around each other in a futile attempt to warm each other once they realized that neither one of them had the key to their houses.

Adora gets hit with so many memories at once. The moments they shared between them in the dark or the way Catra would curl an arm around her and whisper something into her ear, something to make her laugh or that would have her playfully rolling her eyes. The way her head would rest on Adora's chest so warmly when they slept together, or the way she smelled like cotton laundry detergent and secret gardens that reminded Adora of days spent at the park. How happy they were to find out they'd been accepted into their dream college, how Adora felt like being in love with Catra might just always be a part of her. She thinks of how they managed to get it so right back then and have only made mistakes since.

In the pools of Catra's beautiful eyes, she sees nothing but an endless stream of memories.

"Did you say something?" Adora asks like she's not about to cry, and watches as Catra's eyes fall shut for a moment.

"Just...just asked if we could go to the music building now," she murmurs, all without opening her eyes. Her eyelashes flutter, and it reminds Adora of butterfly wings, delicate and soft and never supposed to be touched.

"Sure," Adora whispers.

Catra opens her eyes. She takes a breath, and then stands and says, "okay , come on."

Adora follows. Before they slip out of the apartment, she looks at the time, and realizes they only have eleven more hours before Catra will go back to pretending like they didn't once mean the world to each other.

hour fourteen.

On campus, they stop at the dorms so Catra can grab a notebook, a binder, and her guitar from her room, then they walk the short distance to the music building. Inside, it's a lot less busy than what it would be if they came during the day, which makes it easier to find an empty practice room with a piano inside. Adora pulls the small, one person couch seat in the corner next to the piano so they can keep their arms close, and then sits down on the chair as Catra gets settled. She feels absolutely exhausted.

"Has...has Glimmer messaged you?" Catra asks, sitting on the bench of the piano. Adora stares at her side profile for a moment. Her eyes are narrowed, and there's sheets of music in front of her that are clearly her own, written and scribbled on.

Adora knits her brows together. "Earlier she asked for an update. I, uh, told her we showered. Why?"

Catra stares at her for a moment, and then shakes her head. "Nothing. She' s just...it' s nothing."

Adora's confused for all of four seconds before it suddenly occurs to her that for the first time in her life, she just confessed to someone

that she’s in love with Catra, and she probably shouldn’t just leave it like that. As Catra takes a breath and then begins to play whatever it is she does, Adora ignores the urge to just close her eyes and listen to the music that feels like gravity toward the sun, magnetic and pulling her in, and uses her hand that’s not dangling above the piano keys to pull out her phone.

Bow

What do you mean you messed it up?

Bow

Adora?

Adora

Don’t tell anyone what I told you

Bow

Okay

Bow

Not even Glimmer?

Adora chews on her lip, hears the sound of thunderstorms and falling buildings coming from the piano echoing in the small room. The song Catra's playing;it advances, a dramatic and haunting form of a melody that's played over and over and over again. It's loud. It's expressive. It's a memory.

Adora

glimmer's okay

Bow

Okay

Bow

Did you talk to Catra?

Adora closes out of her messages. Whatever Catra had been playing before slows, slowly growing softer and quieter like petals falling from a flower. It keeps going until almost nothing can be heard, until all is silent in the room. Adora stares at the side of Catra's face, at her sharp jaw and the corners of her lips which can curve into something sharp and dangerous;at her constellation of freckles and her blue eye that reminds Adora of oceans and lakes and rivers and waterfalls.

Catra takes a breath. Her eyes are narrowed, tongue poking at her cheek, before she grabs a pencil and starts writing on the sheets she brought with her. Adora leans forward a bit to give her a wider range to move.

"Did you write that?" she asks, despite already knowing the answer.

Catra hums, brows knitted together in concentration before she nods. "Yeah. It's it's for one of the community theatres; some new musical. They wanted a complex tragic piece, so I'm trying to add more minor key changes."

Adora nods along as if she understands music fundamentals whatsoever. "They asked you to write for them?" Catra hums again, and Adora smiles. She says, honestly, "That's really cool. I'm proud of you."

For a moment, Catra seems taken aback. Adora wonders if she's gone too far, but then Catra's lips curve into the edge of a smile and she says, "thanks."

She plays the fast and loud part again; slower this time, like she's trying to figure out what's wrong with it or what she needs to change. Adora watches her play; watches her eyes close, fingertips seemingly dancing along the keys, Adora's cuffed hand hovering close by. She looks so peaceful, so at home like she's always looked whenever she's creating music, and all Adora can think about is how much she's missed watching her do this.

Why did you stop wanting to be around me? fills her head. She has to take a breath as a flood of thoughts suddenly seems to surround her; she can feel herself starting to get overwhelmed by the thoughts that haven't seemed to leave her head at all in the past two hours. *We were supposed to be fine. You told me it was fine.*

I think I love you too much. I think I've always loved you too much.

I'm sorry I messed everything up. I'm sorry I can't change what happened.

Adora clenches her fist. Catra pauses for a long moment, and just as a lovely chord echoes in the room, Adora blurts out,
"what *happened* to us?"

Catra freezes. The sound of the piano goes away .

"Why did..why did you push me away?" Adora asks, and her voice sounds defeated even to her own ears.

There's a moment where Adora thinks Catra isn't even going to respond, but then she whispers, "you know why ."

"You said we were fine," Adora argues. *Even though you didn't want me, it was fine. It was okay, because we could still be friends.*

Catra still hasn't torn her gaze away from the keys of the piano. She looks sad now, small and young like the day she first opened up about Weaver's abuse. Adora blinks the tears away from her eyes.

"I'm *sorry,"* she murmurs. It feels like all she's been trying to do these past two years is apologize.

Catra doesn't say anything else. They sit there in silence for a long, long time before her fingers begin to move along the keys again, and it feels like the rest of them are lost to the music.

-

hour fifteen.

Catra mindlessly strokes the strings of the guitar she's supposed to be focused on, but doesn't do much more than that. Next to her, Adora lies curled up on the seat of the couch, head tilted back and eyes closed, arm cuffed to Catra's stretched out and dangling over the space between them. She dozed off about half an hour ago, and Catra thinks this entire trip was futile, because she hasn't been able

to focus on anything she should've been focusing on ever since Adora prodded at her.

What happened to us?

Why did you push me away?

You said we were fine.

I'm sorry.

Catra scoffs to herself, strumming the guitar a bit louder. What the fuck is Adora even sorry for? Catra's the one who pushed her away; the one who couldn't handle being around her after everything happened. It was all too much ~~-sh~~e loved Adora too much, and she couldn't handle being around someone she loved and having to pretend like everything was fine even though everything *wasn't* because she loved Adora and Adora didn't love her the same way.

On the top of the piano, her phone buzzes. Catra takes a deep breath, carefully sets her guitar back into its case, and then slides open her messages.

glimmer 2:23

catra

Catra tenses upon staring at the message for a moment. Each time Glimmer has messaged her today it's been in the group chat with Entrapta, but this is a direct message.

glimmer 2:23

has adora talked to you yet?

catra

about?

glimmer

idk, anything deep, personal, in like the last hour

Catra knits her brows together in confusion, but chooses not to qestion Glimmer ’s strange motives.

catra

um... no, she’s been asleep for a while

catra

if you’re texting for an update, we’re in the music building. we’ll probably go back to my dorm in a while.

catra

has swift wind pooped out the key yet

glimmer

look, let's just forget about the project for a moment

glimmer

and no he did not

glimmer

but anyway i have to tell you something

Catra flashes another glance at Adora. Her hair is falling out of the ponytail she put it in after they showered, and her face is lax and void of any emotion. She looks peaceful. She looks beautiful. She looks like someone who deserves the entire world.

catra

what is it?

glimmer

okay

glimmer

the project is real. me and entrapta do need it for our grades

glimmer

but there’s another reason i chose you two that i didn’t mention

glimmer

well, uh, actually, entrapta kinda almost gave it away

Catra furrows her brows together. *Adora obviously wants to be friends, but Catra keeps pushing it off,* is what Entrapta had said earlier this morning.

She frowns.

glimmer

look, only i know this

glimmer

i didn’t even tell bow really any of it because of how sad adora was about it

glimmer

but a couple of weeks ago, me and adora went out to a club and got drunk

glimmer 24

and adora got, like, really fucking drunk

glimmer 24

she doesn’t remember, but she told me what happened to you guys that night

glimmer 24

it was after everyone left

glimmer 24

she kissed you?

glimmer 24

you pushed her away, and said you’d talk about it later, but never did. you left, and you two never talked about it, ever

glimmer 24

it’s why you guys suddenly stopped talking

glimmer 24

is all of that correct?

Catra swallows heavily. Her hands are shaking so badly she’s not sure how she manages to type.

catra 24

yes

glimmer 24

okay

glimmer 24

catra, i don’t know how you feel about it all

glimmer 24

i don’t know why you pushed her away, both when she kissed you and afterward

glimmer 24

but i do know that this has been fucking with her for years

glimmer 24

she thinks it’s her fault that you guys stopped being friends

glimmer 24

and she’s never forgiven herself for it

glimmer 24

i know that it hurts you too. i don’t know whether or not you have feelings for her, but i see the way you look at her sometimes, too. it’s not as obvious as the way adora looks at you, but it’s there

glimmer 24

i know you’d rather it not be this way

glimmer 24

and i figured you two being together for twenty four hours would encourage you to finally talk about it, but clearly it isn’t if she’s already asleep

Catra's frown deepens. *How does she know we haven't talked about it before this?*

glimmer 25

please just talk to her

She doesn't even realize she's crying until a single tear drop splashes onto the screen of her phone, seeping through the cracks. She shuts her phone off, setting it down on her lap.

No matter how hard she's tries to erase the events of that night from her memories, she can never seem to succeed. It's all too fresh, as if it just happened yesterday —she can still remember most of the details, a little too clearly.

She remembers it had been the day Adora had moved into her apartment, and that she had promised to help her unpack after the rest of their friends left upon helping them get everything into the apartment. Remembers the moment she felt something shift in the air;remembers that Bow and Glimmer had just left, and Catra had suggested they open a bottle of wine to drink to celebrate Adora finally having enough money to have her own place.

She thinks that was the first mistake.

The second was letting Adora drink glass after glass while she only had one.

"Hey , hold on," Catra had started, one drink and two hours after everyone left as they continued unpacking, "oh my God, so many of these clothes are mine. I mean, some of it I don't even really —wait, what the fuck, I've spent like three years looking for this sweater."

She heard Adora laugh somewhere behind her, followed by the feeling of hands on her waist and a face resting on her shoulder to peer down at the box Catra was currently unpacking. "Hey , don't act like you don't also have a lot of my clothes. You're literally wearing my flannel right now!"

Catra hummed, leaning into the warm and comforting weight behind her. There was jazz music playing in the background, Adora' s old vintage record player having been one of the first things they unboxed.

"What are you going to do here?" she asked, eyes fluttering shut at the feeling of Adora's hands, once on her waist, moving higher and higher until her arms were wrapped around her chest to pull her impossibly closer. She found herself wrapping her own arms around Adora's; found herself wishing they were more. "It' s it' s big. Feels like it'll get too lonely."

Adora was silent. Catra opened her eyes, before she slowly turned in Adora's arms. The girl in mention watched her for a moment, and then slowly brought her hands back down to her waist, pulling them closer. Acting on instinct, Catra brought her arms to wrap around Adora's neck.

"Is this okay?" Catra asked, quietly . They were so close then that Catra could smell the alcohol on Adora's breath, could see the darker flecks of gray in her bright blue eyes. She could see the freckles that were just barely there, unable to be seen unless you were really close.

"Of course," Adora told her , and her smile was filled with warmth, wildfires in her soul. It was dangerous. It made Catra fall just that much more in love with her. "Are you forgetting we've danced before?"

"I know ," Catra breathed, because she did, but.. something about here and now felt different. She didn't know what it was, just that it felt *so* different.

They were quiet for a while, simply swaying to the music playing in the background. Adora stumbled over a box on the floor, and they giggled when they nearly fell onto the floor. It was peaceful. It was everything Catra could ever want.

Almost.

"To answer your question from before," Adora took a breath, and Catra wasn't sure if it was sometime between the stumbling or if they just did it on their own will, but their foreheads were pressed together then. "I don't think it'll be lonely . I'll have you, right?"

At that moment, Catra pulled her head away. Her gaze found Adora's, and they stopped swaying;stopped moving altogether . It was moments like these that fueled the acute longing in Catra. It was this and it was sleeping next to each other with mingled breaths and it was small touches in the dark to ask if she was alright and it was the way Adora's arm wrapped around her shoulders when Catra was cold that caused her to think maybe, maybe they could be something more.

I don't know, she wanted to say. *I think I'm falling in love with you. I think I already am, and I don't know what it means. I don't know how to stop, and I don't know what to do. I've heard that it kills people to love someone who doesn't love them back.*

"Yeah," Catra had breathed instead, and Adora had smiled. It was smaller than before, quiet and unspoken like a promise that felt like it was breaking before it was even made sure.

"You'll always have me too," Adora told her , "I promise."

In retrospect, she should've listened to the feeling that was telling her *this is too much, this is too much, stop it before something happens,* but she didn't. She let Adora lean in to press their mouths together;felt how soft and chapped her lips were, felt Adora' s pulse point speed up beneath her thumb. Tasted the alcohol they'd been drinking on her tongue, kissed her back and hoped it would leave her

lips bruised and red and ruined to leave evidence that it was real, that it happened, that this wasn't just some fantasy in Catra's mind.

It was so unlike how they'd previously been; the kiss wasn't soft, and it wasn't gentle. It was rough and teeth and biting and grabbing and maybe it was all of those things that made Catra realize, *what are we doing?*, but when her mind caught up with her body, she wrapped her fingers around Adora's wrists to pull her palms away from her face.

She's drunk, Catra thought, unable to pull her eyes away from Adora's lips, swollen and red. "We can't—we shouldn't be—"

You've never shown any interest in me before this, is what she wanted to say. *I can't do this if you only want me just because you're not in the right state of mind right now.*

"I'm sorry," Adora blurted out, and before Catra could say something like *it's okay, it's okay, I'm not mad, I never could be,* she recoiled so quickly that Catra almost wondered if she burned her, yanking her wrists away and standing with her eyes wide. "That didn't—*I* didn't—I wasn't trying to—I didn't mean to do that. I'm sorry, I'm sorry."

And Catra had stood there, arms wrapped around herself with the fresh memory of Adora's lips on her own and thought, *oh. Well, that's what I thought.*

"Okay," she breathed. "Okay. You're...you're drunk, and...maybe we should just talk about this later."

What is there to talk about? She didn't mean it.

But Adora had agreed, and that had been it. Catra had made sure she showered and got into bed, put a glass of water and aspirin on the empty bedside table next to her and left once Adora fell asleep despite telling her she'd stay; had gone over to Scorpia's and Perfuma's and had cried because she knew what it felt like to kiss and be in love with her best friend. She knew what it felt like to see

the shock on her face afterward and hear that she didn't mean to do it.

And in the days after, when they met and saw each other again, they didn't say anything about it. It was awkward and stiff;Adora never seemed to know what she wanted to say, and Catra didn't know how to bring it up without saying something like *I love you, I know now that I love you, and you kissed me because you were drunk and it clearly didn't mean anything and I don't think I can stand to be around you anymore if you don't feel the same way because it hurts too much.*

"Are we.okay"?Adora had nervously asked at one point;maybe three or four days after they actually kissed.

"W e're fine,"Catra muttered through clenched teeth, and then they never actually talked about it. She's not sure when it happened, but as the weeks began to blur together and every time she saw Adora after that it was always with Adora trying to act like everything was normal, like it never happened, it all became too much. She couldn't handle being around Adora as if she wasn't literally head over heels in love with her and Adora just wanted to pretend like it didn't happen.

So that was it. They didn't see each other for weeks, and by then it was easier for Catra to feel a sense of anger for Adora, of resentment for kissing her despite not feeling anything, then it was to feel hurt over the fact that it didn't mean anything. They never talked about it, and months and then years passed. Catra dated other people, but she could never have long lasting relationships with them. It never lasted.

("Why don't you talk to her anymore?" she remembers Perfuma asking, and Catra had shrugged and simply said, *"It's easier this way.")*

And now twenty-six months later they're here, having been handcuffed together for the past fourteen hours, and Glimmer's just

told her that Adora thinks it's her fault that they're not friends anymore as if it's not Catra's fault for falling love with her in the first place and forcing herself to push her away in order to get over her. She thought it worked, but one look at Adora and she knows that it didn't.

Catra stares at her reflection in the black, cracked screen on her phone. She closes her eyes, takes a deep breath, and then reaches for Adora's shoulder to give it a gentle shake.

"Adora, hey ," she whispers when Adora' s eyes slowly flutter open, "I think we need to talk."

*

Chapter End Notes

wanted to get this up before midnight so...happy new year everyone whether you're reading this in 2021 or 2022!here' s to hoping 2022 isn't as much of a dumpster fire as the rest of the 2020s has been even tho that doesn't seem likely !

end

Chapter Notes

apologies for the long wait on this, life has gotten extremely busy

See the end of the chapter for more notes

(Adora doesn't need to sidestep living room boxes anymore, and Bright Moon's city noise no longer keeps her up at night. White-framed pictures of her friends and family are hung up in the hallway, and her pantry is full of her favorite snacks and guilty pleasures.

Things that remind her of Catra are there, too.

It's been two weeks since they've spoken, and a month since things have even had a semblance of normalcy. Catra claimed they were fine, but it's become clear that they're *not,* that Adora's moment of acting on her growing desire of want may have ruined everything.

It was lonely here in the apartment, just like Catra said it might be. Unlike what she ~~A~~dora didn't have her anymore, and she wasn't sure whether or not she should keep pretending like nothing ever happened in a futile attempt to hang on to the thread of normalcy they had before the kiss.

As of now, it's lonely and quiet and there's a Spotify playlist on in the background, but the room seems unbearably silent as Adora lays sprawled on her bedroom floor. She's been crying for hours, sobbing with her cheek pressed uncomfortably against the carpet, occasionally letting strings of thoughts about Catra and love and regret fill her mind.

I don't know what I was thinking, she thinks, staring up at the ceiling with dazed eyes. *I don't know how I could've let myself done that. I don't know what to do now.*

While sleeping that night, Adora dreams of relationships falling between her fingers like liqid;dreams of the qiet, delicate bubble all of their lives seemed to exist in up until recently. When she wakes up the next morning, she feels so nauseated by nostalgia and sadness that she skips class and calls into work, and spends the day laying in bed watching the sun paint shadows on the walls and ignoring calls from her friends. She thinks about how much she would change if she could go back in time a couple of months, or even jst a few weeks. How much harder she'd fight to keep herself from acting on selfish wants.)

-

hour sixteen.

Outside of the music building, the air nips chillingly at them, and it smells like smoke and snow. It's gotten a lot colder in the few hours they'd been inside as winter seemingly really sets in. Tonight's a chilly night, and Catra feels like she'd enjoy the small flakes starting to fall from the sky if it weren't for how upset Adora looks.

She's mad;mad at Glimmer for telling Catra about what she said, and mad at Catra for everything else.

"You know what?" Adora asks, running her hand through her hair for the millionth time. It's a mess, hairs falling out of her ponytail on either side of her face;it's *been* a mess since Catra woke her up, told her they should talk, and then explained everything Glimmer had said to her. "You're right. We do need to talk about it. We *needed* to talk about it two years ago."

“Adora,” Catra stage-whispers, anxious, “I didn’t know how. I wanted to at first, but you just kept making it seem like you wanted everything was normal, like it never happened.”

“Because I *wanted* things to be normal!” Adora rushes out, finally turning to face her. Her cheeks and are red from the cold, and her eyes are watery. “You pushed me away, and I—I just wanted to forget about that.”

“Well of course I pushed you away,” Catra scoffs, waving her uncuffed hand in the other direction. The handcuffs feel more restricting than ever. “You were—you were drunk, you didn’t know what you were doing, of fucking course I’d push you away”—

“Who are you to decide that?” Adora interrupts, and her voice quiets down. “Who are you to say I didn't know what I was doing? I was perfectly aware of my decisions and what I was doing. I”—

“Adora, you were *drunk,”* Catra hisses between clenched teeth. “You were drunk and you could’ve been—I don’t know, experimenting or something, you had just moved into a new apartment and talked about being lonely and it just—it wasn’t right.”

Adora is silent, unreadable. It only serves to make Catra’s frustration with this situation rise. Adora’s always been easy to read, but never in times like this.

Catra closes her eyes, takes a deep breath, and counts to four.

“I just wish you would’ve meant it,” is what she sighs, hands balled up into fists. She feels apprehensive, already dreading Adora’s reaction.

Apparently, she was right to do so. When she opens her eyes, there’s a rising surge of fire visible in Adora’s eyes;something Catra hasn’t seen in her in a long time.

"Are you fucking kidding me?" she spits, and it feels like they're falling. It feels like they're drowning. It feels like they're being suffocated; like they already have been for a while. "You just assumed I didn't mean it? This whole time you just assumed that I was just fucking—I don't know, experimenting with my best friend? That I was just lonely and desperate? That I hadn't been crushing on you for years?" Adora's *furious* now; her eyes are full of tears, and she jabs a cold finger into Catra's chest, hard enough to push her back a step. "If you think that's all that was…"

Catra grits her teeth, but doesn't make a move to push Adora away from her. Her thoughts are all over the place right now, and she stutters over herself in an attempt to gather the right words. "That's not—I didn't—" she waves her hands sort of uselessly. "That's all it was. It was just a stupid crush or an experiment or something, and I couldn't handle—"

"God, are you even listening to yourself right now?" Adora asks, voice raising again. A couple of people pass them and flash them weird looks, but Catra doesn't pay them any mind. *"Just a stupid crush?"*

"That's what you made it seem like!" Catra snaps, finally feeling the hurt and anger for everything boil over. Her brows are knitted together, and she shoves Adora's shoulder. *"You're* the one who kept making it seem like nothing ever happened. *You're* the one who immediately pretended like nothing ever happened. *You're* the one who made it clear that it didn't mean as much to *you* as it did to *me."*

She accents the final word with another shove; this time, Adora staggers back a couple of feet, and Catra is pulled with her. They stumble off the sidewalk and into the grass; Adora grabs Catra's wrists to keep her from running into her, and they simply stand there for a moment, unspeaking. Catra glares at Adora's neck, refusing to look up and make eye contact with her.

"It meant something to you?" Adora finally asks, breaking the silence. Her voice is a lot softer now, and Catra scoffs again.

Something in the back of her mind is telling her not to say these next words;that there' s a good chance she might regret it for the rest of her life. Another voice is telling her to just go ahead;they've already gotten this far into it, so she might as well say the rest.

"Of course it did. Of fucking course it did, Adora. I've been— *fuck,* I've felt so much for you for years, and you just—you kissed me, but then you—then you didn't mean to, and"—she pulls her wrists from Adora's grasp, running a hand through her hair and then using the back of her arm to wipe the tears that have fallen from her eyes.

"Felt so much for me?" Adora questions, confused. Catra doesn't say anything, so Adora keeps going. "But that doesn't make any sense," she points out, a weak whisper that Catra only hears because of how quiet it is where they are right now. It's a stark contrast to how she sounded a minute ago. "You dated other people. You avoided me. You didn't..."

"Because you didn't want me," Catra says, exasperated. "I messed around with other people because you didn't want me, but it...it never lasted. I was always dragging them on because I could never"—she trails off for a moment, staring down at her feet. "After you, I just...it never worked. But I didn't"—Catra pauses to take in a shuddering breath. "I couldn't handle being friends with the person who broke my heart. It hurt too much, being around you, knowing what it was like to kiss you and knowing you'd never want me the same way. Knowing that I *love you,* and you could never feel the same."

Her voice is wet, and it cracks somewhere toward the end.

Around them, snow falls to the ground. The street lights illuminating the cement walkway allows Catra to see the way Adora's lips part a little, giving away her surprise.

Catra takes a deep, shuddering breath.

I love you.

She said it. She actually said it.

She can’t even look at Adora right now.

She brings her arm up to cross over her body in a fruitless attempt at self-comfort;usually , she’d do it with both of her arms, but one of them is kind of occupied. She feels numb because of the cold and the fact that she’s still wearing a t-shirt, but her heart is beating so fast and the blood is roaring so harshly in her ears that she doesn’t even really register it.

I love you.

Adora is utterly, horrifically silent.

Catra can’t even look at her.

It’s so quiet that Catra can hear the chirps of the crickets and grasshoppers, can hear the boisterous laughs and cheers from what’s most likely a college party at the frat house a little ways away from them. A couple exits the music building but heads in the opposite direction of them, their voices floating through the cold night.

Everything around them continues to move and breathe.

I love you.

Silence. Complete and utter silence.

Then: a hand in her hand, and—

“You love me?” Adora asks, and her voice is quiet and disbelieving. Catra thinks the tears on her cheeks must have frozen to her skin by now, and she lets out a bout of laughter despite the fact that nothing about this is funny. Adora’s hand is gentle in her own, rough and calloused in the best way.

"Yeah, dummy," she says, voice trembling. Her heart is beating *so* fast. "I love you. I always have. And I... I'll get over it. I *will.* Being with you, today... it's made me realize I want you in my life again, but I don't think that can happen until I'm over you. I just... I need some more time, okay?"

There's another few seconds where neither of them speaks. Catra swallows harshly, wipes her eyes, and continues to refuse to take her eyes off of the floor. She's considering all the different ways this'll go; Adora will probably either be disgusted with her, or mad she never told her, or something worse, or—

And then the hand in her hand releases, and for a moment, Catra thinks *it's done. It's over, nothing's going to change. I'm so, so stupid,* but then she feels that same cold hand against her cheekbone, gently guiding her face up, thumb stroking softly.

The snow crunches underneath Adora's boots as she closes the distance between them, pressing herself right up against Catra. She has a lovely smile on her face, much to Catra's confusion, and she's so much warmer than anything and everything else out here that Catra finds herself instinctively curling into her.

"Catra," Adora starts, "I've been in love with you since we were seven years old."

Wait.

What?

"And I..." Adora takes a breath, "I thought you knew? Up until, like, five minutes ago, I thought you. Um. Knew that."

Catra blinks.

What?

"Because when—when I kissed you, I guess I never took into consideration that I was drunk, I just kind of saw it as myself taking that chance, and you pushing me away and like, never talking to me again. So I kind of thought you knew and you were disgusted or something and that was it."

"I—Adora, what does this—" apparently Catra can't seem to make a full sentence. "What are you *talking* about? Since we were *seven*—*?*"

"And fuck, okay," Catra doesn't even *know* where to begin processing what's happening; Adora never really curses, but she's also never said stuff like *this.* "I love you too, okay? I love you so much that it hurts. Like, it actually, physically pains me sometimes. I really can't believe you didn't know that."

"I—what," Catra bristles, only a little offended; she feels like something in her is warm now, and she's still trying to process everything. "You didn't know that I loved you either, so."

"You weren't obvious about it," Adora points out, and her smile still has the radiance of a thousand suns. "Pretty sure I was, even if I wasn't trying to be."

"Okay, well, that's funny, because when you're looking at it objectively"—

"Catra," Adora interrupts, and now their faces are a lot closer, separated by mere centimeters. Catra can see the breath escaping Adora's mouth due to the chill, can feel it against her own lips. "Can I kiss you?"

"Can you kiss me?" Catra asks, and she thinks she might be hysterical now. Her voice is a bit high in pitch. "God, seriously? You're seriously asking if you can kiss me when that's all I've wanted for years? Seriously? *Seriously?* What the fuck?"

"I should've asked the first time," Adora whispers, and now she sounds mournful. Catra knows it's because of all the time they lost that shouldn't have been lost in the first place. "I shouldn't have kissed you without asking or while I was drunk, and I'm sorry, so now I'm trying to make up for that. I love you, and I'm asking you now: can I kiss you?"

Catra leans in to kiss Adora this time.

This time, it's soft, and it's gentle. This time, it's warm and so, so sweet. This time, Catra knows Adora's kissing her back because she loves her. This time it's just them, kissing in the dark on campus as it gets close to midnight because they love each other. It's dizzying and intimate and everything Catra wanted.

Adora loves her.

Adora loves her.

Adora loves her *back.*

She's crying again, even more than she was before. There are countless tears falling down her cheeks, and her face is a weird mix of heat because of everything that's happening and cold because of the weather. Adora pulls back when she feels the tears;she uses her thumb and the back of her hand to wipe them away despite the fact that they just keep coming, despite the fact that she too is crying.

She pulls away to press a kiss to Catra's forehead, and then brings her closer again to wrap her up in a hug. It's a bit awkward because she can only use one arm, but Catra doesn't care. She uses her own non-cuffed arm to wrap around Adora's waist, and presses her face into her shoulder.

"I'm sorry ," Catra apologizes, hiccuping between the words. "I'm so, so sorry. This whole time I thought I—I should've just"—

"Shhh," Adora hushes; it comes out a bit shaky because she's also taking in shuddering breaths. "It's okay. It's okay. We're okay."

Catra doesn't know how long they stay like that, wrapped up in each other in freezing weather and wearing clothes that definitely aren't appropriate for the time. She just keeps her face buried in Adora's shoulder, trying her best to go through the simple breathing exercise Perfuma taught her in order to calm herself down.

If it were anyone else, Catra wouldn't be here. If it were anyone else, she probably wouldn't have agreed to this whole experiment in the first place no matter how much she was bribed. If it were anyone else, she wouldn't be standing outside close to midnight in only an oversized t-shirt and sweatpants that are a bit too long for her in fifteen degree weather in order to have a long overdue conversation.

But it's Adora. It's Adora, who's sweet and kind and so, *so* selfless, and Catra's in love with her. It's Adora, who apparently loves her back. Catra doesn't know how, or why, but she does. Adora loves Catra.

"I know you were being serious," Adora eventually whispers after what feels like hours—but must have only been minutes—later, "but can you just tell me you were being serious? Like, I've been through a lot of emotions in the past twenty minutes and I just need"—

"I'm serious," Catra says, and feeling slightly more calm now, she pulls away from Adora's shoulder and wipes her eyes. This time, she looks Adora in the eyes when she says, "I love you. I've loved you for a long, long time. I'm so, *so* serious. More serious than I've ever been about *anything.* I'm so fucking in love with you, Adora. I tried getting over you after what happened because I thought you didn't feel the same way and I thought I did but I *didn't.* No matter how hard I tried, I never could."

"Oh," Adora says. "Oh, okay," and then they're kissing again.

They’re in public, next to a streetlamp and it’s *so fucking cold,* and they’re kissing. Catra is kissing Adora, and Adora is kissing her back just as eagerly . Adora’s kissing her like she’s never been kissed before, and it’s so good and so, so nice. Adora kisses her like she wants to kiss her tomorrow, and the next day, and maybe for a long time after that.

(Catra is perfectly okay with that.)

hours seventeen through twenty-four.

Despite the fact that Catra thinks she could just live with kissing Adora forever, she pulls back when she realizes just how hard they’re both shivering and that she’s starting to lose feeling of an alarmingly large part of her body. Adora’s lips (her glorious lips) are red and swollen from the kissing, and Catra finds herself staring at them.

(She did that.)

(She can’t believe she did that.)

They end up rushing to the dorms after the mutual agreement that they’ll both probably obtain hypothermia if they walk to Adora’s apartment because it’s further away. Adora helps Catra carry her things, and when they get inside, Catra plugs in the small heater she has and they spend fifteen minutes sat in front of it, trying to regain feeling in their fingers.

Adora falls asleep again on Catra’s shoulder this time, probably far more used to going to bed well before midnight, and Catra wakes her up by pressing her lips to her cheek, gently encouraging her to wake up so they can change and get into bed. Adora’s a bit more sluggish with it at first;she looks like she’ s teetering the line of being

asleep and awake, and Catra giggles (only *Adora* could get her to *giggle)* and helps her get her shirt through the cuffs and lets her borrow one of hers, which ends up being only slightly tight and more like a crop top.

They share Catra's bed for the first time in over two years, lying face to face, cuffed hands between them. Adora's eyes are half closed, but she has a hand on the back of Catra's neck, fingers gently scraping against the nape of her hair.

"That feels so good," Catra whispers, and she can't help but let her eyes flutter shut. "You've always been so good at that."

Across from her, Adora chuckles.

"I missed you," she says, and she's so quiet that Catra can barely hear. "I missed you so much. Not a day went by where I didn't get reminded of you and just think about how much I missed you."

"I missed you too," Catra breathes. "I'm sorry that I avoided you for so long after we kissed. I knew you still wanted to be friends, but I… I thought you'd get over it. I thought I was just breaking my heart, not yours."

Adora hums for a beat. "It's okay. I forgive you. And I'm sorry for kissing you while I was drunk, and for making you think that I didn't want you by pretending that it didn't happen. I think I could've handled it a bit better."

Catra smiles and opens her eyes; intertwines their cuffed hands and brings Adora's hand to her lips. "It's okay. We both could have."

Adora returns the soft smile, but then suddenly pinches her brows together. "You know what I just realized? I can't even be mad at Glimmer now."

Catra purses her lips. "I guess so, but she still put us through a lot. She *and* Entrapta."

"T rue," Adora agrees. "God, in the shower"…

"Mhm," Catra hums. "I wanted to kiss you so badly in the shower . I think I knew I was fucked the moment the suggestion we shower together left my mouth."

Adora snorts. It's fucking adorable. "And when we fell when we were ice skating? I nearly kissed you right then and there."

"Me too. And the gym? I was seriously having a major meltdown watching you lift those weights."

Catra opens her eyes when Adora doesn't respond, and knows she's made a mistake when she realizes that Adora is looking at her with a smug, albeit sleepy, expression.

"Oh, really?" she asks innocently , and then proceeds to take her hand off of the back of Catra's neck to flex. Catra swallows at the sight of her muscles, and then rolls onto her back to shake her head.

"Suddenly I regret this entire thing. Maybe we *should* go to the hardware store to cut these things off."

"The hardware store is closed."

"Fuck."

"Y ep. You're stuck with me now."

"Damn. Guess the universe just hates me or something."

Adora giggles and leans forward to press her lips against Catra's. When she pulls away, she rolls onto her back, pats her chest, and then looks at Catra expectantly.

"Y ou're ridiculous," Catra laughs, but scoots closer and rests her head on her chest, immediately feeling far more comfortable than she has in months. Their cuffed hands rest on Adora's abdomen.

"You love it," Adora mumbles, and Catra can tell she's on the verge of falling back asleep.

"Yeah," Catra whispers. "I do."

Minutes later and Adora is quite obviously asleep; Catra knows because she makes the same quiet, soft snuffling noises she's always made while she sleeps. Her chest rises and falls beneath Catra's head like a sleepy metronome, and Catra presses a soft kiss to her collarbone. She reaches over Adora to grab her phone, turns her brightness all the way down to avoid waking her up, and finally checks her messages.

glimmer [redacted]

catra? are you going to talk to her?

glimmer [redacted]

catraaaaaaa

glimmer [redacted]

catra.

glimmer [redacted]

CATRA

glimmer [redacted]

fine if you want to ignore me go ahead i hope you suffer

glimmer

i’m sorry i didn’t mean it i really do hope you two stop being oblivious and work things out

Catra grins, and then uses her hand to thumb in her response.

catra

we did

Glimmer’s response comes immediately.

glimmer

WAIT SWEUOSLY

glimmer

MY PLAN WORKED?

glimmer

ARE YOU GUYS T OGETHER NOW? WHA T HAPPENED?

glimmer

FUCK IF I W ASNT AT BOWS PLACE ID COME INTO UR DORM RN ASSUMING THATS WHERE U ARE

glimmer

WHAT HAPPENED DID YOU BOTH T ALK

Catra grins mischievously. She thumbs out of her messages with Glimmer and then puts her contact on mute. Glimmer may have technically helped them tremendously today, but Catra's still allowed to be a little mad. Even if deep down, she well and truly isn't, Glimmer can wait till the morning to know what happened.

Instead, she thumbs over to her messages with Scorpia.

scorpia

hey wildcat. me and perfuma are turning in for the night, i hope everything's going alright

scorpia

call me if you need anything, okay?

catra

everything’s alright. we talked

Everything’s *better* than alright, Catra thinks with a smile.

scorpia

talked?

scorpia

about what?

catra

i thought you went to sleep

scorpia

i got up to pee and just got into bed when i saw your message

scorpia

and now i want to make sure you’re okay

scorpia

and i may be slightly curious as to what happened

catra

we talked about what happened that night. and we made up

scorpia

wait seriously?

scorpia

did you tell her about your feelings?did she reciprocate them?

catra

?

catra

how did you know i had feelings for her?

scorpia

catra you were literally inconsolable that night

catra

but was it really that obvious i had feelings?

scorpia

ok i'll admit it

scorpia

perfuma figured it out and told me

catra

that makes more sense

catra

but anyways

catra

yes i told her about my feelings.

scorpia [01/01/2021]

oh my god wildcat i’m so proud of you!

scorpia [01/01/2021]

what did adora say? does she feel the same?

catra [01/01/2021]

against everything i ever thought, she does

scorpia [01/01/2021]

OMG!

scorpia [01/01/2021]

are you two dating now? can i be the maid of honor at your wedding?

catra [01/01/2021]

we haven’t talked about it yet, but if she wants to, then we will. which i think she does

catra [01/01/2021]

date, i mean

catra

littleeee too fast for marriage

scorpia

haha

scorpia

but seriously. i’m really happy and proud of you, catra

catra

thank you. i appreciate the support

scorpia

:)

-

after.

"So," Glimmer starts, scratching the back of her head. "I have good news and bad news."

They're back at Adora's apartment, and Swift Wind has finally been returned to her; presumably, because he pooped out the key. It's just past eight in the morning, which means they made it the full twenty-four hours. Catra lays curled into Adora's side, having fallen back asleep after being woken up at seven-thirty when Adora got the messages from Glimmer requesting they meet at Adora's apartment so they could *finally get rid of this dog,* and woke up a grumbling Catra and promised her she could go back to sleep when they got to her place. Adora doesn't even want to *know* what time she finally went to sleep last night.

"What is it?" Adora asks.

Glimmer glances at Bow, and then Entrapta, who's sitting on the chair at the table with a notepad and her phone in hand. She clears her throat.

"So, um, the good news is I have the key. The bad news is Swift Wind never ate it, because I kinda found it. In my pants. That I apparently took off after the party."

Catra's eyes immediately snap open, and she picks herself up so fast that she nearly smacks her head against Adora. "You *WHAT?*"

"In my defense!" Glimmer says, voice a bit shrill, "If I hadn't thought I lost the keys, this," she motions between Catra and Adora, "may not have been fixed, so, you're welcome."

Adora chances a glance at Catra. She still looks severely annoyed, but when their eyes meet, something in her expression changes. Her shoulders relax, and she sighs, before reaching forward to accept the key Glimmer's handed out to them, and then passing it to Adora.

"You could've just, like, told us you knew ," Catra grumbles as Adora fumbles to unlock the cuffs. For some reason, a part of her feels like she's going to miss them, even if they're starting to make her wrists a bit raw. Maybe she'll have to invest in her own pair. "Instead of handcuffing us together for twenty-four hours."

"It was a double whammy ," Glimmer argues. "You two makeup, and me and Entrapta get a good grade. You can't blame me for that."

"We fell during Adora's hockey practice," Catra huffs. Adora manages to get Catra's cuff off first, and then sets to working on her own. "I almost died."

"We had to walk around all day without proper winter clothing," Adora backs her up after she gets the cuff off her wrist. Catra springs to her feet.

"We had to embarrass ourselves in a public bathroom," she adds, pointing an accusing finger at Glimmer. "Where's my money?"

"You still want me to pay you? I thought fixing your relationship with Adora would be enough. I got you a *girlfriend!"*

The word *girlfriend* makes something warm and soft sprout in Adora's chest. Catra purses her lips and crosses her arms. She's very clearly deep in thought, and Adora thinks it might be the cutest thing she's ever seen.

"Fine. But I'm still not paying you back for that ticket and you're still doing my laundry," Catra says, before flopping back down onto the couch with her arms crossed.

"Can we get started on the post-experience interview now?" Entrapta asks, standing from her seat in the small kitchen. She has a large, maniacal smile on her face;if they weren't good friends by now , Adora would be a little terrified. "I'm really excited to see if my hypothesis is correct."

"Don’t think that I don’t remember the role you had to play in the torture me and Adora went through yesterday," Catra grumbles, still sulking into the couch. Adora wraps an arm around her shoulders and presses a kiss to her hair, relishing in the way Catra leans into her and ignoring the gagging noise Glimmer makes and the thumbs up Bow gives them.

Clearly disregarding what Catra just said, Entrapta places her phone down, presses record, and then holds up her notebook. "Okay , so, my first question is what are your most prominent feelings now that you’ve reached the end?"

"Betrayal," Catra grumbles. "Discovered I can't trust any of my friends."

"Relief," Adora simply adds.

"Feelings of betrayal for the conductors of this experiment, relief to be out of the situation, very good." Entrapta says as she writes. "What else?"

"I’m dying of hunger , to be honest," Adora continues. "I’ve usually gone on my morning run and started breakfast by now. You two are the reason I’ve missed two of my runs and am dying from lack of sustenance."

"Y es, yes, all expected," Entrapta giggles as she scribbles in her notes. "My next question is, do you feel closer to each other now that the experiment has been concluded? Any particular feelings that have changed?"

Adora blinks, and then shifts so that she can look down at Catra, who seems to get the same idea and looks up at her.

Their eyes meet.

"I don’t know , Catra," Adora teases, "have your feelings changed about me?"

"Not really ," Catra smirks. Adora smiles, and thinks about yesterday; how she couldn't stop thinking about how beautiful she was at the beginning of this entire thing, and how that's one thing that hasn't changed. "I still very much dislike you." Catra tips forward, mouth still split in a beautiful smirk, and brushes her lips against Adora's. Adora can *feel* the smile, and feels so overwhelmed with love and affection and happiness in this moment that she thinks she might burst.

"and they begin to make out, therefore answering the question," Adora tunes back in to hear Entrapta saying, no doubt writing it all down. She couldn't care less.

"Can we make them leave?" Catra whispers against her lips. "I'm tired and we need to start catching up on all the cuddles we've missed out on for the past two years."

A part of Adora can't believe she gets to have this now. The other part can't wait to get started.

"We'll leave once you give us some information on the past nine hours," Glimmer speaks up. "All we have to piece together is the cryptic message Catra sent me at one in the morning."

Catra rolls her eyes, and Adora snorts. "We fought a bit, made up, cleared up what happened that night, kissed, and then went to Catra's dorm and fell asleep."

"It was super cold outside," Catra adds. "Literally the worst fucking night of my life. Fuck you all."

"Thanks!" Entrapta says cheerfully , before gathering her things. "I'll leave you two to make out now," she waves at everyone, and then leaves. Glimmer and Bow stare at the space where she once stood.

"Alright, well, we're going to make out whether anyone else is here or not, so, unless you'd like to see that," Catra makes a sweeping motion with her hand.

"I'm going to quote you on that," Glimmer says, before grabbing her things and heading out of the door. Bow simply flashes them another thumbs up, and then makes sure to shut their door when he follows his girlfriend.

Catra doesn't even make a move to kiss Adora, or to change positions. She just lays back down, cuddling into Adora, and goes back to sleep.

Adora has quite literally never been happier.

A week later, they find the handcuffs on the door to Catra's dorm, as well as a copy of the paper Glimmer and Entrapta wrote that has an *A+* written in the corner and *+10* for supposed extra credit. There's a little sticky note on top of the cuffs that says *felt too significant giving these back to my dad, so i managed to get them replaced. you're welcome!* in Glimmer's handwriting.

Two days later, Glimmer is being handcuffed to her bed post. Catra makes sure to message a picture of said situation to Entrapta and captions it *you're next.*

"Are we evil?" Adora asks after shutting the bathroom door to Glimmer's dorm; she and Catra are actually pretty similar, and one example of that is that they both aren't morning people in the slightest, so Adora wasn't surprised to see that Glimmer was still asleep. She doesn't think they'd take too kindly to someone pointing out the fact that they are quite similar, though.

"Nah, she deserved it," Catra has a mischievous smile on as she wraps her arms around Adora's neck. They left the key out of Glimmer's reach, but her phone is next to her. She'll probably be fine.

"True," Adora agrees, and hides a smile in her hair.

Catra is a constant in her life again. She's mischievous and she's smart and she's beautiful, strumming a guitar on the couch of Adora's apartment in one of her t-shirts or cuddling up warmly to her at night. Those are things that are familiar. There are new things now, too; there's the lazy kisses in the early hours and the reassuring touches that go further than they ever did, and there's the love that they say equally through their actions and their touches and their words.

In the mornings when Catra is still asleep, sometimes Adora can't help but stare at her and wonder how she got so lucky. She runs her fingers through Catra's hair or traces the pad of her thumb along Catra's freckles and thinks about the fact that it took them being handcuffed for twenty-four hours straight to get to this point; wonders how much longer it would've taken them without that, and wonders what that says about them as people.

But Catra is a constant again. She's a present, reoccurring figure in Adora's life, and Adora is still just as in love with her as she's always been.

And when Catra wakes up, her pretty eyelashes will flutter and her beautiful eyes will find Adora's, and she'll cuddle closer to her and rasp, "hey, Adora."

"Hi."

They look at each other for a moment.

"What," a yawn, "what are you thinking about?

Everything, Adora thinks.

"Are we really doing this?" Adora asks, and feels her lips begin to curl into a smile without her permission. Not that she's complaining. "Girlfriends?"

"Yes," Catra tells her. Her voice is raspy and sleepy, and she woke up less than a minute ago, but she speaks without an ounce of hesitation. "Yes, we are. That's good, right?"

"Yeah," Adora agrees, "that's really, really good," and then Catra's pushing herself closer and kissing her eyelids, her cheekbones, her smiling mouth. *Not just good,* Adora thinks, all while giggling and smiling and gripping Catra's waist. *We're going to be great, gonna be amazing, gonna be so much better than good—*

And they are.

*

Chapter End Notes

i think this is my first finished multi chapter fic? like i also have another multi chapter that finished but that was just a one shot i split up so i don't count it so i'm actually quite proud of this

my goal is to try to finish the last chapter of my other fic but i also am finding inspiration to write new things for catradora cause it's been two years but i still just. love them sm. so i'll most likely just start a ficlet collection of prompts (which i will probably open my tumblr for requested prompts)

thank u all for taking the time to read this fun little thing, and if ur still here i hope u enjoyed :)

End Notes

comments and kudos as always are appreciated, and u can find me on twitter and tumblr

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!